Module: Killing the Options
Lesson 3.1: DISTORTION – Scope Error

The Spectrum: From Truth to the Absolute Lie

Before we kill the options, we need to understand how they are engineered. Think of every option as a point on a spectrum of **logical validity.**

- **The Pure Truth (The Anchor):** This is the idea established in the passage. It is the "Sacred Boundary." The correct option will always stay within this fence.
- **The Truth Converter Machine:** This is how the correct answer is born. It takes the *soul* of the passage and gives it *new clothes*. It uses different words (paraphrases truths) or logical consequences/implications (implied truths), but it **never** violates the boundary.
- **The Distortion (The Funhouse Mirror):** This is where most students die. A distortion isn't necessarily a "lie." It's often a version of the truth that has been twisted, stretched, or squeezed. It *smells* like the passage, but it is fundamentally unfaithful.

The **S.T.E.A.L.S.** framework is your forensic kit to catch these distortions:

- **S**cope Error (Our focus today)
- **T**one Mismatch
- **E**xtreme Position
- **A**lien Idea
- **L**ie
- **S**idetrack

LESSON HANDOUT

What Exactly is Scope?

Scope is simply **The Boundary.** Imagine the author has built a beautiful, small garden. They are talking about *this* specific rose in *this* specific corner.

- **Scope Broadening** is like claiming the author is talking about every rose in the entire world.
- **Scope Narrowing** is like claiming the author is *only* talking about the left-most petal of that specific rose.

Both are **Rotten.** Why? Because the passage does not provide enough evidence for the "Broad" claim, and it doesn't give you permission to "Narrow" the claim to only one tiny subset.

Why Scope Error is More Dangerous than an Alien Idea

An **Alien Idea** is easy to spot. It's a stranger at the party. If the passage is about whales and the option talks about space stations, you kill it instantly.

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But a **Scope Error** is a guest from the invite list who has wandered into the wrong room. It uses the same keywords as the passage. It uses the same characters. It feels "intellectual." But it quietly stretches the claim until it snaps.

The Two Crimes of Scope

1. Scope Broadening

This happens when an option takes a limited, local truth and inflates it into a general theory or a global phenomenon.

- **Example:** If the passage says, "Some residents in this building were unhappy," the trap will say, "The city is facing a crisis of dissatisfaction."
- **Logic:** You've taken a "some" and made it "to a larger group". You've taken a "building" and made it a "city." The author has no authority over the city based on this text.

2. Scope Narrowing

This happens when the author makes a broad point, but the option tries to restrict it to one specific group or one specific instance mentioned in the text.

- **Example:** If the passage says, "Modern technology has changed how humans communicate," the trap will say, "Smartphones have changed how teenagers talk to their parents."
- **Logic:** While technically "true" that smartphones and teenagers are involved, the passage was about *all* humans and *all* technology. By narrowing it, you are ignoring the larger point the author established.

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LESSON HANDOUT

The Passage:

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The latest method to go viral promises a more concrete solution: youngsters are turning to the Brick, an app-blocking device. . . . The grey cube, which costs $59 and is about the size of an AirPods case, claims to reduce screen time by three hours a day on average. To use the device, you choose the apps you would like to disable and touch your phone to the "brick". When you are ready, you can tap your phone against it to "unbrick". . . .

There is a paradox at the heart of the current trend, however. Gen Z may have declared 2026 "the year of analogue", but they have done this on TikTok. The Brick has gone viral on social media. . . . Perhaps that is why most digital detoxes fail: people are quickly drawn back to screens and apps.

However, many say the Brick is the best tool they have tried yet. The secret is to place "distractions out of reach", says Thomas Driver, the company's co-founder: "Temptation is sidelined until you physically return to the Brick." In a digital world, this bricks-and-mortar approach has merits.

— Source: Addicted to your phone? Try "bricking" it, The Economist

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The Boundary Map (The Fence)

Before we look at the traps, look at what is *actually* in the garden:

1. **The Problem:** Universal desire for less screen time.
2. **The Context:** Bizarre internet hacks exist (chaining phones, etc.).
3. **The Focus:** A specific device called "The Brick."
4. **The Observation:** The irony of using social media to promote an anti-social-media tool.
5. **The Conclusion:** Physical distancing is a legitimate psychological strategy.

Anything outside this is a trespasser.

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LESSON HANDOUT

Walkthrough: The Example Sets

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Example Set 1: Virality and Social Media

Passage Extract: *The latest method to go viral promises a more concrete solution: youngsters are turning to the Brick, an app-blocking device. . . .*

The Truth (Converted): *The Brick has gained significant public interest through digital platforms.*

Logic: This is a **valid paraphrase**. "Significant public interest" is a truth-converted version of "gone viral." "Digital platforms" is a safe umbrella term for "social media." This option stays perfectly inside the fence.

Scope Error – Broadening: *The popularity of the Brick indicates a global movement against smartphone addiction.*

Logic: "Viral on social media" does **not** equal a "global movement." Virality is a trend; a movement is a coordinated, organised social shift. Furthermore, "smartphone addiction" is a heavy, clinical diagnosis. The passage only discusses wanting to "spend less time" on phones. This option inflates a local trend into a worldwide revolution.

Scope Error – Narrowing: *A small group of Gen Z influencers is experimenting with a physical app-blocking device.*

Logic: The passage says the device went "viral." Virality implies a mass, broad audience, not just a "small group." While Gen Z is mentioned as the group declaring the "year of analogue," restricting the entire phenomenon of the Brick to only "influencers" and only a "small group" unfairly squeezes the author's claim.

Example Set 2: Internet Suggestions

Passage Extract: *The internet (ironically) has some ideas: chain your mobile to the wall; print out your Instagram feed on dozens of pieces of paper; or practise "appstinence" by ditching the device for long stretches.*

The Truth (Converted): *Online communities propose various unconventional strategies for reducing device dependency.*

Logic: "Online communities" = "The Internet." "Unconventional strategies" = "Chaining your phone to the wall." This is a valid paraphrase that preserves the boundary.

Scope Error – Broadening: *Screen-time reduction has generated a range of organised, institutional responses.*

Logic: Chaining your phone to a wall or printing your Instagram feed are *scattered, bizarre hacks*. They are the opposite of "organised, institutional responses." This makes the situation sound like a government policy or a formal programme. The author never suggests these ideas are coordinated or formal.

Scope Error – Narrowing: *TikTok is the primary platform used to promote unconventional strategies for digital detoxing.*

Logic: The passage says "the internet" has ideas. TikTok is only mentioned later in a specific paradox about Gen Z and the Brick. We cannot take the "internet's" ideas and narrow them down to a single "primary platform" called TikTok.

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Example Set 3: Digital Detox Failure

Passage Extract: *Perhaps that is why most digital detoxes fail: people are quickly drawn back to screens and apps.*

The Truth (Converted): *The difficulty of resisting digital impulses often leads to the failure of attempts to withdraw from technology.*

Logic: "Difficulty of resisting impulses" = "People are drawn back." "Attempts to withdraw" = "Digital detoxes." This preserves both the scope and the strength of the original claim.

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Scope Error – Broadening: *Modern society is inherently incapable of sustaining a lifestyle independent of digital tools.*

Logic: The author said "most detoxes fail" because people like apps. They did **not** declare a civilisational death sentence for "modern society." This is a sweeping, philosophical diagnosis that the text doesn't support. It turns a local failure into a universal law.

Scope Error – Narrowing: *Young users frequently abandon their appstinence goals due to peer pressure on social media.*

Logic: Where is "peer pressure" in the text? Nowhere. That's an **Alien Idea** mixed with **Narrowing.** The passage says they are "drawn back" by the apps themselves, not necessarily by peers. Furthermore, the passage says "people" detoxes fail, not just "young users."

Example Set 4: The "Bricks-and-Mortar" Value

Passage Extract: *In a digital world, this bricks-and-mortar approach has merits.*

The Truth (Converted): *In a digital environment, non-digital interventions may have value.*

Logic: "Digital environment" = "Digital world." "Non-digital interventions" = "Bricks-and-mortar approach." "May have value" = "Has merits." Perfectly preserved logic.

Scope Error – Broadening: *Physical solutions are generally more effective than digital ones in managing technology use.*

Logic: The author said the Brick "has merits." They didn't say it's "generally more effective" than everything else in existence. Don't turn a specific compliment into a general hierarchy. This is a massive broadening of a tentative, local observation.

Scope Error – Narrowing: *The bricks-and-mortar method may help Gen Z manage their screen habits.*

Logic: While Gen Z is mentioned in the passage, the author's final claim about the "bricks-and-mortar approach having merits" is a general conclusion for *anyone* in the digital world. By restricting it to only Gen Z, you are narrowing a universal takeaway into a demographic footnote.

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LESSON HANDOUT

The Final Takeaway

A Scope Error is **Subtle.** It often uses the author's own vocabulary to trick you into a false sense of security.

- **Doodling is your shield:** When you identify the "Key Idea" of a paragraph, you are defining the fence. If an option asks you to step outside that fence, you must refuse.
- **Don't match words; match boundaries:** Just because an option says "Gen Z" and the passage says "Gen Z" doesn't make it right. Ask: *Is it talking about Gen Z in the same way?*

Respect the boundary. Kill the trespassers.

Module: Killing the Options
Lesson 3.1: DISTORTION – Alien Idea

In the previous lesson, we looked at **Scope Error**. There, the distortion came from taking an idea the was present in the passage and then twisting its boundary. The option either broadened the claim or narrowed it. So the idea belonged to the passage, but the treatment of that idea was distorted.

Now we move to something slightly different: **Alien Idea**.

An alien idea is not merely a "stretched" version of the passage. It is something that is **not even discussed** in the passage. It does not belong to the passage-world at all. It enters the option like an uninvited guest at a wedding and then sits there pretending it was always part of the family.

That is the trap. And yes, this is a serious trap. The data from CAT shows that Alien Ideas make up a meaningful chunk of the wrong options. We break them into three broad forms: **Projection, Wrong Word, and Extension.**

LESSON HANDOUT

What Exactly is an Alien Idea?

An alien idea is a concept, claim, or angle that the passage **never** discusses. Period.
Every passage has a **Boundary**.

- **Scope Error** distorts something *inside* that boundary.
- **Alien Idea** brings in something from *outside* that boundary.

Most students fall for this because they read an option and think:

- *"This sounds like something the author could have said."*
- *"This feels like a reasonable extension."*
- *"I don't remember reading this, but it feels related."*

Sounding like is not enough. *Feels like* is not enough. *Feels related* is not enough.

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The only question that matters is: **Did the passage actually give me this idea?** If the answer is no, then it is **Rotten**. It is alien idea

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Alien Words IS NOT NECESSARILY Alien Ideas

Do not be that student who sees one unfamiliar word and screams "Alien!" A correct option can use different words—that's called **Paraphrased Truths**. It can derive VALID inferences—that's called **Implied Truths**. The option might have words not found in the text, but if the *idea* is faithful, it's a friend.

The Distinction:

- **Alien Word:** Different vocabulary, same passage idea. (Safe!)
- **Alien Idea:** New concept, zero passage grounding. (Deadly!)

The Three Traps: How Alien Ideas Appear

1. Projection

This is when the option tries to predict the author's future. It assumes what the author is *likely* to say next or what they *probably* believe. "The author *may* go there next" becomes "The author *is definitely* saying this now."

2. Wrong Word

This is subtler. The option swaps a key word for something that sounds close but changes the entire **Conceptual Frame**. It piggybacks on your expectation of a paraphrase to sneak a lie past you.

3. Extension

The most blatant form. A fresh concept is just parachuted into the option. No basis. No grounding. It just looks "intellectual", so you're afraid to question it.

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— *Source: Addicted to your phone? Try "bricking" it, The Economist*

The Boundary Check

Before we kill, we map the territory. The passage discusses:

1. Reducing screen time (The problem).
2. Quirky/Drastic hacks (Chaining phones).
3. The Brick device (The method).
4. The social media paradox (The irony).
5. Physical distance vs. Temptation (The logic).

The Forbidden Zone (Alien Idea Territory):

Ethics, Behavioral Psychology, Legal Regulations, Environmental Costs, Capitalism, Cognitive Limits.

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LESSON HANDOUT

The Examples

Category 1: Alien Idea as Projection

Example A: *The rise of Brick underscores the need for more ethically designed digital ecosystems.*

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Example A: *The rise of Brick underscores the need for more ethically designed digital ecosystems.*

Logic: This sounds very posh. It sounds like something an IIM professor would love. *But it is 100% alien.* The passage never mentions "ethics." It doesn't talk about the moral design of apps. It doesn't hint that developers are responsible. If you pick this, you are "projecting" a serious discussion that hasn't happened yet.

Example B: *The effectiveness of physical deterrents lies in their impact on users' impulse-control mechanisms.*

Logic: This is "Psychology 101" being smuggled in. The passage says the device puts things "out of reach." It *never* discusses the internal biological or cognitive "impulse-control mechanisms" of the user. The author isn't diagnosing your brain; they are describing a grey box.

Example C: *The appeal of analogue tools signals a broader cultural resistance to digital capitalism.*

Logic: This is the "Macro Trap." You took a $59 gadget and turned it into a war against "Capitalism." The text doesn't mention capitalism, economics, or broad cultural resistance. It's just about people wanting to stay off TikTok. This is a massive theoretical projection.

Example D: *The paradox surrounding the Brick illustrates the tension between technological convenience and human cognitive limits.*

Logic: "Human cognitive limits"—what the hell is that? It sounds so smart you're afraid to say it's wrong. But where is it in the text? Nowhere. The author mentions the paradox of being on social media to talk about detoxing, but they never frame it as a "cognitive limit." Don't be hypnotised by fancy words.

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Category 2: Alien Idea as Wrong Word

Example E: *Practice "appstinence" by dismantling the device for long stretches.*

Logic: The passage says "**ditching**" the device. Ditching means putting it away. **Dismantling** means taking a screwdriver and opening it up. One word swap, and the entire activity is now alien to the passage. It's a conceptual wreck.

Example F: *In a digital world, an innovative approach has merits.*

Logic: This is sneaky. The author calls it a "**bricks-and-mortar**" approach. That implies it's *physical and old-school*. If you call it "innovative," you change the frame. The author isn't praising it because it's "new" (innovative); they are praising it because it's "tangible."

Category 3: Alien Idea as Extension

Example G: *The renewed interest in analogue tools signals a cultural redefinition of authenticity in the digital age.*

Logic: Who invited "**authenticity**" to the party? This is a brand-new philosophical concept parachuted into the option. The passage is about screen time, not about being "authentic" or "real." This is a pure conceptual trespass.

Example H: *Legal frameworks may be necessary to regulate excessive engagement on social media platforms.*

Logic: Suddenly we are in a law school exam. "Legal frameworks"? "Regulation"? The passage is about a consumer product and personal habits. It never mentions the law or government intervention.

Example I: *The environmental costs associated with manufacturing digital detox devices warrant closer scrutiny.*

Logic: Just because there is a device (The Brick) doesn't mean we are discussing its "environmental cost." This is taking a noun from the passage and attaching a random, unrelated topic to it.

Final Takeaway

Alien ideas often trap you because they sound ***plausible***. They sound like the kind of things smart people say about technology. But under exam pressure, "plausible" is your enemy.

1. **Stop completing the author's argument.** If the text didn't say it, don't help the author out.
2. **Beware the "Hypnosis of Sophistication."** If an option uses heavy words like *authenticity, capitalism,* or *cognitive limits*, verify their existence in the text.
3. **Respect the Boundary.** *Different words can be Truth. Different ideas are always Alien.*

Module: Killing the Options
Lesson 4.1: DISTORTION – Tone Mismatch

The Central Idea: Respect the Author

Tone Mismatch is largely about one thing: **Respect the author.** That is it.

➔ Respect what the author is saying.

➔ Respect *how strongly* the author is saying it.

➔ Respect whether the author is saying it at all.

➔ Respect whether it is the author's own view or somebody else's view being mentioned.

If an option does not do that, you have a **Tone Mismatch**.

LESSON HANDOUT

Boundary and Intensity

By now, you should know that most distortions violate one of two things:

1. **The boundary** of the discussion.
2. **The intensity** of the discussion.

Scope and Alien Idea largely violate the **boundary**. Tone Mismatch largely violates the **intensity**.

That is why Tone Mismatch is often easier to spot. The option may stay roughly within the same topic, but the moment it starts making the author sound more certain, more aggressive, or more committed than the passage allows, the alarm should go off.

Why Tone Mismatch Matters So Much

Because RC questions often ask:

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Because RC questions often ask:

➔ According to the passage...

➔ According to the author...

➔ Which of the following would the author agree with?

➔ Which one best reflects the author's view?

Now imagine the passage is **expository**. The author is explaining something, not taking a strong stand. If an option suddenly makes the author sound like a *crusader*, that is a problem.

Or imagine the passage is **analytical**. The author is exploring nuances without taking a firm position. If an option turns that into a *definitive conclusion*, that is a problem.

So Tone Mismatch is often about:

➔ wrongly attributing a view to the author

➔ overstating the author's certainty

➔ changing a tentative claim into a definitive one

➔ turning a descriptive passage into a prescriptive one

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LESSON HANDOUT

The Passage

LESSON HANDOUT

THE PASSAGE

Time is elusive. . . . We have no sensory organs for detecting it, nor any dedicated brain areas for tracking it. Our experience of time can vary hugely: minutes drag if we're bored or uncomfortable; hours race if we're excited or having fun; we can easily be fooled about how much time has elapsed. And in certain circumstances, our sense of time can even go in circles, break apart or stop altogether. . . .

Rather than being mere mistakes or distortions, these effects reflect something deeper: the role we all play in creating our own time. Because even cosmologists, measuring the universe, don't find any moving river of time: most believe there's no physical flow of events beyond our perception, no moment of "happening" or "becoming" in which the future slips into the past. Quantum physicists come up empty-handed, too. . . .

Time, then, is less a universal truth than a feature of how we interact with the world. This insight is reflected in the way some indigenous communities experience time. . . . This gives us a different way of thinking about how our lives progress that might be able to release us from the relentless beat of the clock. Lived time is different from clock time because it isn't defined by a numerical counter that chops things into seconds, or milliseconds, or microseconds. Each moment is more like a tapestry, woven from changes wreaked on multiple timescales.

— *Source: Is time a figment of our imaginations?, The Guardian*

THE AUTHOR'S POSITION IN THE PASSAGE

The author takes three broad positions:

1. **Time is experienced subjectively.** That comes from the first paragraph. The author shows that our experience of time varies widely. Minutes drag. Hours race. So yes, time is experienced subjectively.

2. **Time *may* not be an objective physical flow.** *Notice the word **may**.* This is very important. The passage says that *most cosmologists believe* there is no physical flow beyond our perception. The author uses that discussion, but the author does not jump into some absolute declaration.

3. **Time is more a human construction than a universal truth.** Again, notice the **comparative language**. The passage says time is *less a universal truth than a feature of interaction*. This is a **measured** position. It is not saying that time is absolutely nothing but human invention.

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THE 4 MAJOR SOURCES OF TONE MISMATCH

1. WRONGLY ATTRIBUTING SOMEBODY ELSE'S VIEW TO THE AUTHOR

Passage says: *"most [cosmologists] believe there's no physical flow of events beyond our perception..."*

✓ **Safer Version:** The author *suggests* that there *may* be no physical flow of events beyond our perception.

✗ **Distorted Version:** The author *claims* that there's no physical flow of events beyond our perception.

Explanation: In the passage, the author is **reporting** what cosmologists believe. They are using that info to build an argument, but they aren't "owning" the claim as a personal settled fact. The Distorted Version pins the view on the wrong person and increases the volume. It takes a reported belief and turns it into an authorial command. **Kill it.**

2. TURNING SUGGESTION INTO PRESCRIPTION (TELLING PEOPLE WHAT TO DO)

Passage says: *"This gives us a different way of thinking... that **might be able to** release us from the relentless beat of the clock."*

✓ The author *reflects* on how certain perspectives *might* offer a release from standard clock time.

✗ The author *argues* that we *should* live like indigenous communities.

Explanation: The word **should** is a massive red flag. Whenever an option uses words like **should, must, have to, or ought to**, you should immediately become suspicious. The author is being reflective and cautious ("might be able to"). They are not issuing a lifestyle command. The distorted option turns a **description** (how others think) into a **prescription** (how you should act). **Kill it.**

3. CLAIMING MORE THAN THE PASSAGE CLAIMS

Passage says: *"We have no sensory organs for detecting it, nor any dedicated brain areas for tracking it."*

✓ The author notes that humans lack specific biological machinery to *detect or track* time directly.

✗ The author *claims* that humans lack the biological basis to *experience* time.

Explanation: This is a very dangerous trap. It uses words like "biological" which sound close to the text. But the passage says we do not have machinery to *detect or track* it. In the very next sentence, it says our **experience** of time varies hugely! If we experience it, we have the biological basis for it. The distorted option overstates a specific lack into a total inability. **Kill it.**

4. TURNING A MEASURED ARGUMENT INTO A "PROOF"

Passage says: *"Time, then, is **less a universal truth than** a feature of how we interact with the world."*

✓ The author *proposes* that time is more a feature of human interaction than a fixed universal truth.

✗ The author *proves* that time is a human invention.

Explanation: **"Proves"** is a muscular word that authors in serious essays rarely use for big philosophical ideas. They suggest; they don't prove. Also, **"human invention"** is far more aggressive than "a feature of our interaction." The distorted option turns a **nuanced comparison** into a **drum-beating certainty**. **Kill it.**

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specific lack into a total inability. **Kill it.**

4. Turning a measured argument into a "Proof"

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LESSON HANDOUT

Qualifiers Matter

This lesson becomes much easier once you start respecting **Qualifiers**. A qualifier is a word that tells you how strongly the claim is being made.

Soft/Measured (Safe)	Loud/Hard (Red Flags)
may, might, perhaps	must, should
likely, less	definitely, never
some, many, few	most, all, none

Look at how these disappear in wrong options.
The passage says "many believe"; the wrong option says "most believe".
The passage says "might be able to"; the wrong option says "we should".

If the author makes a hard position in the passage, then a hard position in the option is a fair game.

A Very Useful Habit

Whenever an option attributes something to the author, ask:

1. **Did the author actually say this?** Or is the option pinning somebody else's view on the author?
2. **Is the author saying it this strongly?** Or is the option increasing the intensity?
3. **Is the author merely exploring?** Or is the option turning that into a command or proof?

If the option becomes louder than the passage, the red flag should go up immediately. Tone Mismatch happens when an option fails to respect the author's actual position.

Lesson Takeaway

➔ Tone Mismatch is a distortion of authorial **intensity**.
➔ Don't turn suggestion into a command.
➔ Don't turn argument into proof.
➔ Don't pin the scientist's view on the author.

In RC, it is not enough to understand the author's idea. You must also understand the author's attitude toward that idea. Respect the author. Hear the voice

Module: Killing the Options
Lesson 4.2: DISTORTION – Extreme

THE GAME PLAN

We have already seen that wrong options can distort the truth in different ways. Some distort the **boundary** of the passage. Some distort the **intensity** of the passage. And now we come to one of the easiest distortions to spot, at least when it is done badly: **Extreme Error**.

In CAT, this is only a small percentage of the overall distortions. That makes sense. Extreme distortion is often too loud, too sharp, too absolute. It is easier to spot than many other traps. But that does *not* mean it is harmless. When an extreme option is dressed well, students still fall for it.

LESSON HANDOUT

WHAT IS AN EXTREME ERROR?

An extreme error is a distortion where the option pushes the claim to an **absolute level**. It takes a statement that is *tentative, qualified, measured, comparative, partial, or context-bound*, and turns it into something *total, final, universal, or uncompromising*.

That is the game.

The shift looks like this:

- **The author says:** maybe, likely, less, more, some, most, may overlook, limited.
- **The option says:** always, never, all, none, decisively, completely, fundamentally, merely, proves, must, should.

That shift is what creates the extreme distortion.

LESSON HANDOUT

What is an Extreme Error?

An extreme error is a distortion where the option pushes the claim to an **absolute level**. It takes a statement that is *tentative, qualified, measured, comparative, partial, or context-bound*, and turns it into something *total, final, universal, or uncompromising*.

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That shift is what creates the extreme distortion.

Two Broad Ways Extreme Distortion Happens

1. Around Quantity

This is about *how much* of something is being claimed. For example: *some, many, most, all, none*. These are **not** interchangeable.

- If the passage says *some*, you cannot casually move to *many*.
- If the passage says *many*, you cannot casually move to *most*.
- If the passage says *most*, you cannot move to *all*.

These are not tiny changes. These are real distortions. And remember something important: **Some simply means at least one.** That is all. It does not mean many. It does not mean most. The moment quantity is exaggerated, the option begins to drift into distortion.

2. Around Intensity

This is about *how strongly* the claim is being made. A passage may say: *may, might, less, more, not found evidence, likely*. The option may turn that into: *definitely, decisively, has no existence, rests on a misunderstanding, fundamentally wrong, merely a fiction*.

That is the intensity problem. This is why extreme distortion often overlaps with tone mismatch. But extreme is easier to separate because here the distortion is so absolute that it becomes especially visible.

Important Caution: If the author takes an extreme position in the passage, then an extreme option is **not** automatically wrong. The issue is never the word by itself. The issue is whether the option **deviates** from the author's actual claim. Distortion means deviation. So if the passage itself says "never", then "never" is fine. But if the passage says "may not", and the option says "does not", now we have a problem.

VARC1000
by Cejo Sreenivasan

LESSON HANDOUT

The Passage

Time is elusive. . . . We have no sensory organs for detecting it, nor any dedicated brain areas for tracking it.

automatically wrong. The issue is never the word by itself. The issue is whether the option **deviates** from the author's actual claim. Distortion means deviation. So if the passage itself says "never", then "never" is fine. But if the passage says "may not", and the option says "does not", now we have a problem.

LESSON HANDOUT

THE PASSAGE

Time is elusive. . . . We have no sensory organs for detecting it, nor any dedicated brain areas for tracking it. Our experience of time can vary hugely: minutes drag if we're bored or uncomfortable; hours race if we're excited or having fun; we can easily be fooled about how much time has elapsed. And in certain circumstances, our sense of time can even go in circles, break apart or stop altogether. . . .

Rather than being mere mistakes or distortions, these effects reflect something deeper: the role we all play in creating our own time. Because even cosmologists, measuring the universe, don't find any moving river of time: most believe there's no physical flow of events beyond our perception, no moment of "happening" or "becoming" in which the future slips into the past. Quantum physicists come up empty-handed, too. . . .

Time, then, is less a universal truth than a feature of how we interact with the world. This insight is reflected in the way some indigenous communities experience time. . . . This gives us a different way of thinking about how our lives progress that might be able to release us from the relentless beat of the clock. Lived time is different from clock time because it isn't defined by a numerical counter that chops things into seconds, or milliseconds, or microseconds. Each moment is more like a tapestry, woven from changes wreaked on multiple timescales.

— *Source: Is time a figment of our imaginations?, The Guardian*

THE AUTHOR'S POSITION (THE TRUTH)

The author is **measured**.

1. Time is experienced subjectively.
2. Time **may** not be an objective physical flow.
3. Time is **more** a human construction than a universal truth.

Notice the language. The author does **not** say: time definitely does not exist independently, time is purely invented, time is a fiction, or time is certainly unreal. *That is the key.* This is exactly why extreme options become wrong. They take a measured position and turn it into a drumbeat.

LESSON HANDOUT

THE EXTREME DISTORTIONS

EXAMPLE 1: FROM MEASURED TO ABSOLUTE

✓ Time is less an independent entity and more a construct shaped by human perception.

✗ Time has **no existence** beyond the structures of human perception.

Logic: *This is extreme.* Why? Because the author has not taken that position at all. The passage says time is *less* a universal truth than a feature of interaction. From that, you can say perception plays a *major role*. But you cannot jump to: *"Time has no existence beyond human perception."* That is an absolute metaphysical declaration. The author is not doing that. **Kill the option.**

EXAMPLE 2: FROM "NOT FOUND" TO "RULED OUT"

✓ Scientific inquiry has **not found** clear evidence of any real temporal flow in the external world.

✗ Scientific inquiry has **decisively ruled out** the existence of any real temporal flow in the external world.

Logic: *This is extreme.* The passage says cosmologists "don't find" a river of time and physicists "come up empty-handed." That means inquiry has **not found evidence**. That is fair. But *decisively ruling something out* is another thing altogether. This is a classic extreme trap. Students slide from "most believe/empty-handed" into "therefore definitely false." **Kill the option.**

EXAMPLE 3: FROM "MAY OVERLOOK" TO "MISUNDERSTANDS REALITY"

✓ Any account of time that treats it as wholly universal or externally real **may overlook** the role of human experience in shaping it.

✗ Any account of time that treats it as universal or externally real rests on a **basic misunderstanding of reality**.

Logic: *Now we have entered theatre.* This is not just strong; it is overcooked. The author suggests such accounts *may* be ignoring human experience. The option accuses them of a "basic misunderstanding of reality." That is a grand, final, dismissive statement. The author is reflective; the option is thundering from a podium. **Kill the option.**

EXAMPLE 4: FROM "LIMITED" TO "FUNDAMENTALLY IMPOVERISHED"

✓ Clock-based time is a **limited** way of understanding human life.

✗ Clock-based time is a **fundamentally impoverished** way of understanding human life.

Logic: *This is stronger than the passage.* "Limited" is one thing. "Fundamentally impoverished" is another. The second phrase is far more severe. It sounds like the author is condemning clock-based time as deeply deficient or damaged. The passage doesn't do that; it merely shows that clock time is not the whole story. **Kill the option.**

EXAMPLE 5: FROM "MORE A FEATURE" TO "MERELY A FICTION"

✓ The apparent movement from future to past is **more a feature** of human consciousness rather than an objective feature of reality.

✗ The apparent movement from future to past is **merely a fiction** generated by human consciousness.

Logic: *That word **merely** is poison here.* The phrase "a fiction" also hardens the claim into an extreme form. The author has not said this. The passage is not saying time's movement is a *pure invention* with no status whatsoever. It is saying it is *more shaped* by consciousness than we assume. **Kill the option.**

✗ Clock-based time is a **fundamentally impoverished** way of understanding human life.

Logic: *This is stronger than the passage.* "Limited" is one thing. "Fundamentally impoverished" is another. The second phrase is far more severe. It sounds like the author is condemning clock-based time as deeply deficient or damaged. The passage doesn't do that; it merely shows that clock time is not the whole story. **Kill the option.**

Example 5: From "more a feature" to "merely a fiction"

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LESSON HANDOUT

Why Students Fall for This

In the exam hall, students often remember the **direction** of the passage but not the **degree** of the claim.

- You remember: *Author is sceptical of objective time.*
- You remember: *Author is talking about perception.*

Then the option comes in and says the same thing, but louder. Because the direction seems right, you miss the distortion in degree. **Intensity matters.** The passage may lean one way; the option shoves it off a cliff.

Lesson Takeaway

Most of the authors you meet in CAT are **sensible writers**. They present views in a measured, logical, and qualified manner. They do *not* usually scream. They do *not* make wild, absolute claims without support.

When an option sounds like a slogan, a manifesto, or a final judgment delivered from the heavens, **pause**. The original author is usually calmer than that.

➔ Watch for red flags: *all, always, never, none, only, must, decisively, completely, fundamentally, merely, proves, rules out.*

➔ Check for **Distortion of Quantity** and **Distortion of Intensity**.

➔ Don't just ask if the option is moving in the same direction. Ask if it is moving with the **same degree**.

Same road. Wrong speed. Kill the option.

Module: Killing the Options

Lesson 5.1: DISTORTION – Sidetrack Truth Type 1

We have looked at lies. We have looked at scope errors. We have looked at alien ideas. We have looked at tone mismatch and extreme distortion. Now we come to the distortion that **CAT absolutely loves.** Not because it is sophisticated or beautiful, but because it is **easy to create and deadly to solve.**

Sidetrack Truth.

If you look at the CAT, sidetrack formed the biggest chunk of distortions. That is not some accident. Question setters love this trap because, from their side, it is cheap to manufacture. From your side, it can be a nightmare.

WHY QUESTION SETTERS LOVE THIS TRAP

Let us say the passage has four paragraphs. A question asks something specific. Now imagine the passage has many truths:

- the main idea
- supporting ideas
- examples
- details
- explanations
- side observations

The question, however, demands **only one specific truth.** That is all the setter needs. They simply lift some *other* true statement from the passage and place it in the options. **Done. Trap ready.**

LESSON HANDOUT

WHY QUESTION SETTERS LOVE THIS TRAP

Let us say the passage has four paragraphs. A question asks something specific. Now imagine the passage has many truths:

- the main idea
- supporting ideas
- examples
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- explanations
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The question, however, demands **only one specific truth.** That is all the setter needs. They simply lift some *other* true statement from the passage and place it in the options. **Done. Trap ready.**

In a main idea question, the central idea is only one among many truths. In a local question, the answer may belong to Paragraph 3, while truths from Paragraphs 1, 2, and 4 can all be used as traps. In a specific function question, the question may ask *why* something is there, while the setter can give you an option that correctly tells you *what* is there. **That is sidetrack.**

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WHAT EXACTLY IS SIDETRACK TRUTH - TYPE 1?

This lesson is about: **True statements that do not answer the specific question.** That line matters. Because most students, when they read answer choices, are searching for truth. That is fine. But in these questions, truth alone is **not enough.** You must ask two questions:

1. Is this statement true according to the passage?
2. **Does this truth answer THIS question?**

If you stop after Question 1, *CAT takes your marks.*

WHY THIS TRAP IS DANGEROUS

Because the wrong option is not obviously wrong. In fact, it often feels comforting.
You look at it and go: *"Yes sir, this was there in the passage."* **Exactly.** That is why you fall for it. The problem is not that the statement is false. The problem is that it belongs to some other part of the passage, some other layer of the argument, or some other question altogether.

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LESSON HANDOUT

THE PASSAGE

Beginning with Isaac Newton in the 17th century, scientists have discovered that there are unbreakable

is our actions that will influence the unfolding of the next chapters in the improbable journey of Big History.

Source: Laws or comets?, by Walter Alvarez, Aeon Essays
Words: 527 | Sentences: 19 | Average Words per Sentence: 27.7 | Flesch-Kincaid Grade Level: 15.3

LESSON HANDOUT

PARAGRAPH-WISE UNDERSTANDING (THE DOODLES)

- **Paragraph 1:** Natural laws govern the physical world. This suggested that maybe there are laws of history too. But the search for such laws has not been successful.
    - **Doodle:** Natural law exists →laws of history doubtful
- **Paragraph 2:** The author moves away from the older dichotomy of history. Instead, he proposes a new dichotomy: **Continuities** (trends/cycles) and **Contingencies** (rare, unpredictable events). Contingency makes laws of history impossible.
    - **Doodle:** Continuities + contingencies → contingency makes laws of history impossible
- **Paragraph 3:** Dinosaur extinction is evidence. Mammals rose because dinosaurs disappeared. Humans exist because of that contingency.
    - **Doodle:** Dinosaur example = contingency with huge historical impact
- **Paragraph 4:** At the life level, contingency is pervasive because organisms are **agents**. They compete to eat and avoid being eaten.
    - **Doodle:** Life level = more contingency because agents act
- **Paragraph 5:** Natural laws provide constraints. But history remains unpredictable because of contingencies.
    - **Doodle:** Laws constrain history, contingencies shape it

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LESSON HANDOUT

BEWARE OF THE SIDETRACKS

Question 1 | Global Question

Which of the following best captures the central argument of the passage?

(1) History unfolds within constraints imposed by natural laws, yet remains unpredictable because of the pervasive role of contingency across different time scales.
(2) The search for laws governing history arose from scientific discoveries, but has been limited by the complexity introduced by living systems and human agency.
(3) Although natural laws structure the universe, the development of life and humanity introduces increasing complexity that complicates attempts to identify overarching historical patterns.
(4) Scientists have discovered natural laws that establish an inherent order in the universe, but laws that govern history have yet to be identified.

- **The Logic:** This is a global demand. You aren't looking for a "True" sentence from Paragraph 1 or an interesting detail from Paragraph 3. You are looking for the *spine* of the entire text.
- **The Passage Evidence:** The passage starts with the existence of mathematical laws (Newton) but notes that laws of history are elusive. It then pivots to the author's own framework: history is a mix of **continuities** and **contingencies**. The final paragraph summarizes this: *"all of it constrained by the laws of nature but playing out in an entirely unpredictable way because of countless contingencies"*.
- **The Anticipated Answer:** The correct answer *must* bridge these two concepts: (1) Natural laws provide the boundaries/constraints, but (2) Unpredictable contingencies are what actually drive the unfolding of history. It has to cover the whole scale—from the Cosmos to Humanity.

Option 1: History unfolds within constraints imposed by natural laws, yet remains unpredictable because of the pervasive role of contingency across different time scales.
Correct Answer: The Question Setter used the **'Truth Convertor Machine'** to combine the two core pillars of the entire passage: (1) laws of nature as constraints and (2) contingency as the source of unpredictability. It spans from cosmic to human scales.

Option 2: The search for laws governing history arose from scientific discoveries, but has been limited by the complexity introduced by living systems and human agency.
Logic (Sidetrack Type 1): This is a **Sidetrack**. It over-focuses on the "search for laws" from Paragraph 1. While true, this is background information, not the *centre* of the argument. The actual engine is contingency, not "complexity." It is a sidetrack because it's a partial truth from the beginning of the passage pretending to be the whole argument.

Option 3: Although natural laws structure the universe, the development of life and humanity introduces increasing complexity that complicates attempts to identify overarching historical patterns.
Logic (Sidetrack Type 1): Another partial summary. It takes Paragraph 4's focus on life and humanity and ignores the "contingency" engine established in Paragraph 2. It is true that this makes historical patterns harder to find, but it's a **Sidetrack** because it replaces the core idea (contingency) with a weaker abstraction (complexity) and ignores the larger scales the author includes.

Option 4: Scientists have discovered natural laws that establish an inherent order in the universe, but laws that govern history have yet to be identified.
Logic (Sidetrack Type 1): This is **Paragraph 1 dressed up as the Main Idea.** Everything here is 100% true. *However*, it stops where the passage *really begins*. It ignores the framework of continuities and contingencies. This is a **Sidetrack** because it's a localized truth from the introductory section that completely fails the global demand of a "central argument".

LESSON HANDOUT

Option 4: Scientists have discovered natural laws that establish an inherent order in the universe, but laws that govern history have yet to be identified.

Logic (Sidetrack Type 1): This is **Paragraph 1 dressed up as the Main Idea.** Everything here is 100% true. *However*, it stops where the passage *really begins*. It ignores the framework of continuities and contingencies. This is a **Sidetrack** because it's a localized truth from the introductory section that completely fails the global demand of a "central argument".

Question 2 | Specific Function

How does the dinosaur example contribute to the author's overall argument?
(1) It highlights how extraterrestrial impacts can alter the course of history.
(2) It gives evidence to the view that predicting the future is often a futile exercise.
(3) It supports the claim that contingency shapes history in massive ways.
(4) It demonstrates how the laws of nature constrain the progression of Big History.

- **The Logic:** This is a **Function** question, not a **Content** question. I don't care *what* happened to the dinosaurs. I care *why* the author is telling me about them.
- **The Passage Evidence:** Paragraph 3 begins: *"Contingencies have impressed me strongly because of the work I've done on the extraterrestrial impact that caused the extinction of the dinosaurs"*. He then explains that mammals only became dominant because of this "contingent rerouting".
- **The Anticipated Answer:** The example exists to provide **concrete evidence** for the "Contingency" part of the main argument. It shows a massive, unpredictable event that completely changed the direction of history. If an option just tells you about asteroids or birds, it's a **Sidetrack**.

Option 1: It highlights how extraterrestrial impacts can alter the course of history.

Logic (Sidetrack Type 1): This is brilliant in a nasty way. It is clearly true. *But* the question asks for the **function** (why), not the **content** (what). The asteroid is evidence; the topic is contingency. This is a **Sidetrack** because it correctly identifies *what* is in the example but fails to explain how it *contributes* to the contingency argument.

Option 2: It gives evidence to the view that predicting the future is often a futile exercise.

Logic (Sidetrack Type 1): Tempting because Paragraph 3 mentions prediction failure. But the function isn't about the *futility* of prediction; it's about the *power* of contingent events to reroute history. This is a **Sidetrack** because it picks up a minor observation from the paragraph instead of the main logical role.

Option 3: It supports the claim that contingency shapes history in massive ways.

Correct Answer: The author explicitly states contingencies impressed him because of this work. The 'Truth Convertor Machine' rewords the asteroid case as a massive shaping of history.

Option 4: It demonstrates how the laws of nature constrain the progression of Big History.

Logic (Sidetrack Type 1): This lifts a true strand from Paragraph 5 and tries to pin it on Paragraph 3. Natural laws and Big History are in the passage, but the dinosaur example specifically demonstrates **contingency**, not constraint. This is a **Sidetrack** because it's a truth from a different part of the passage being used as bait for this specific function question.

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LESSON HANDOUT

Question 3 | Vocabulary-in-context

The word 'agent' as used in the passage most clearly refers to which of the following?

LESSON HANDOUT

Question 3 | Vocabulary-in-context

The word 'agent' as used in the passage most clearly refers to which of the following?
(1) a passive player affected by contingency
(2) an evolutionary progress
(3) an active player in history
(4) a complicated being

- **The Logic:** You need the meaning *in this specific context*, not a dictionary definition.
- **The Passage Evidence:** Paragraph 4 says: "*...each organism is an 'agent', selected by nature to be good at obtaining nourishment and at reproducing. Each agent is competing with others of its kind...*". The author says this makes things "more difficult to understand" because these agents create new "opportunities for contingency".
- **The Anticipated Answer:** An "agent" here is an **active participant**. It is something that *behaves, competes, and acts* in ways that make history unpredictable. It is the opposite of a passive object that just follows a simple mathematical law.

Option 1: a passive player affected by contingency
Logic (Lie): Direct lie. The passage says agents act and compete. They are active participants who *create* opportunities for contingency.

Option 2: an evolutionary progress
Logic (Sidetrack Type 1): It picks up nearby language ("evolution progresses") to fool you. An agent is a participant, not a process. This is a **Sidetrack** because it uses nearby passage words that have nothing to do with the lexical definition.

Option 3: an active player in history
Correct Answer: This captures the meaning in context: an organism that acts, competes, and shapes outcomes.

Option 4: a complicated being
Logic (Sidetrack Type 1): The passage says things become "more complicated" *because* of agents. The setter is gambling that you'll remember the word "complicated" being nearby. It is a **Sidetrack** because the adjective belongs to the *situation*, not the word's definition.

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LESSON HANDOUT

Question 4 | Local

Each of the following is a valid example of contingency EXCEPT:
(1) falling in love during a surprise encounter changes a person's future.
(2) a recommendation of a book alters the direction of a person's intellectual development.

LESSON HANDOUT

Question 4 | Local

Each of the following is a valid example of contingency EXCEPT:
(1) falling in love during a surprise encounter changes a person's future.
(2) a recommendation of a book alters the direction of a person's intellectual development.
(3) a habit of reading gradually shapes the way a person thinks and makes decisions.
(4) an unforeseen illness significantly alters the subsequent direction of a person's life.

- **The Logic:** You have a definition of "Contingency". Three options will fit in the "Contingency Bucket." One will not.
- **The Passage Evidence:** Paragraph 2 defines contingencies as: (1) rare events, (2) that make significant changes, and (3) could not have been predicted far in advance.
- **The Anticipated Answer:** I am looking for the one option that is **not** a contingency. Based on the author's dichotomy, the opposite of a contingency is a **Continuity**—something that is a *trend, a cycle, or a gradual, predictable process*.

Option 1: falling in love during a surprise encounter changes a person's future.
Valid Contingency: "Surprise" = unpredictable. "Changing future" = impact.

Option 2: a recommendation of a book alters the direction of a person's intellectual development.
Valid Contingency: A specific, unexpected event that alters a trajectory.

Option 3: a habit of reading gradually shapes the way a person thinks and makes decisions.
Logic (Sidetrack Type 1 - Correct Answer): This is the correct answer. It is a **Sidetrack** because it is a "Continuity" wearing contingency makeup. "Habit" and "gradually" are the hallmarks of steady development—the *opposite* of rare, unpredictable events. True in life, but belongs to the wrong conceptual bucket.

Option 4: an unforeseen illness significantly alters the subsequent direction of a person's life.
Valid Contingency: "Unforeseen" practically waves the flag for unpredictable events with massive impact.

LESSON HANDOUT

WHAT THIS LESSON IS REALLY TEACHING

Sidetrack truth is not merely an option problem. It is a lethal combination of two specific failures:

1. **Comprehension failure** You didn't understand the *key idea* of the passage or the paragraph properly. Your doodles are weak. Your mental map is blurry.
2. **Question-demand failure** You didn't clearly see what the question was *actually* asking. You read the words, but you didn't process the specific *demand*.

When these two combine, sidetracks become *deadly*. Why? Because any statement that is factually true according to the passage starts looking like a soulmate.

THE EXTRA STEP YOU MUST MASTER

In your standard process, truth-checking is necessary. But in the world of Sidetracks, truth-checking is *not sufficient*.
When there are multiple options that are true, you must add one extra step:
"This is true. *Fine.* But what question is it answering?"
That is the shield. That is the entire lesson.

HOW TO KILL SIDETRACK TRUTH - TYPE 1

- **First, understand the passage properly.** If the central ideas are weak in your head, every true sentence in the options will start looking important. You will fall for a Paragraph 1 truth in a Paragraph 4 question every single time.
- **Second, decode the exact demand.** What is the question *actually* asking for? Is it the main idea? The function? A context-specific word meaning? A local detail? Or an example?
- **Third, anticipate the answer space.** Before you let the Question Setter distract you with their "True" options, *anticipate* what the correct answer should look like based on the passage. Define the logic of the answer *before* you read the choices.
- **Fourth, the Final Audit.** When you see a true option, *do not celebrate*. Stop. Ask yourself: "Does this truth satisfy the *specific demand* of the question I just decoded in Step 2?" **That final check is the shield.**

Module: Killing the Options
Lesson 5.2: DISTORTION – Sidetrack Truth Type 2

We have already looked at Sidetrack Type 1. There, the trap was relatively straightforward. The question had a specific demand, and the Question Setter gave you a true statement that did not answer that specific question. That itself was dangerous enough. But now we move to a more evil version.

Sidetrack Truth Type 2.

This one demands a little more work from the setter and a little more alertness from the student. In Type 1, the setter could simply pick up another true statement from the passage and throw it into the option. In Type 2, the setter starts **building traps**. The two most common ways in which this happens are:

- **False Connection**
- **Twists**

That is the lesson.

LESSON HANDOUT

WHAT IS SIDETRACK TYPE 2?

Let us imagine a passage with four paragraphs. An idea **X** is mentioned in Paragraph 1. Another idea **Y** is mentioned in Paragraph 3. The passage never connects X and Y. But the option does. It says something like:

- X caused Y
- Y happened because of X
- X depends on Y
- Y changed the nature of X

That connection is not in the passage. The setter has **forced** it. That is a **False Connection**.

The second kind is the **Twist**. Here, the setter picks up an actual idea from the passage. Almost everything in the option looks right. The words feel familiar. The direction feels familiar. But then a small twist is added. That twist changes the meaning. It could be a scope issue. It could be an alien addition. It could be a lie. But as a trap, it works through a twist in a passage-idea.

LESSON HANDOUT

What is Sidetrack Type 2?

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This is why Sidetrack Type 2 is dangerous. While reading the options, you feel that all the words belong to the passage. You feel that you have seen these terms before. That sense of familiarity makes the option attractive. But familiarity is not truth. And truth is not enough unless the option preserves the exact relationship given in the passage.

The Ultimate Pain

This is where the real pain happens:

- The passage is dense.
- The ideas are abstract.
- The options are full of passage words.
- The setter forces a connection or introduces a twist.

The only way to deal with this pain is the same old medicine:
Read the passage slowly enough to understand the key ideas. Then kill the options quickly.

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LESSON HANDOUT

The Passage

. . .We exist as physical beings, but we experience our selves as ephemeral coalitions of thought and feeling, forever bounded by flesh and bone. Words, endlessly ambiguous, are grievously imperfect vehicles for

LESSON HANDOUT

THE PASSAGE

. . .We exist as physical beings, but we experience our selves as ephemeral coalitions of thought and feeling, forever bounded by flesh and bone. Words, endlessly ambiguous, are grievously imperfect vehicles for communication to another mind. Through them we give others not a window to our being and meaning, but a foundation on which to build their own. . . .

Love attempts to remedy this problem, but it can only flourish when we treat each other as ends rather than merely means. . . . We can go further, to observe that any relationship pursued merely for personal gain adheres to. . .inhuman logic. To demand that our partners are there only to improve our own lives, and vice versa, is to reduce the boundless wonder of intimacy to a transactional exchange of benefits – to reduce it to the logic of capitalism. . . . In the reduction of love from human expression to pure transaction, a. . .process of alienation occurs. And historically, we see that marriage has frequently followed these instrumentalist contours: wives were often reduced to domestic servants and child rearers, to vessels of patrilineal property descent; husbands reduced to patriarchs and providers. . . . .

The gutting of the labour movement (making striking illegal, etc) brought with it an erosion of the working class gains which formed the material basis of working class prosperity under the post war consensus: of long-term well-paying jobs, stable living standards, the opportunity to buy a home to raise a family in, and so on. The loss of these things is mirrored in the sociocultural extension of adolescence which is the decline of love as a mature commitment to another's humanity, and its replacement with a capricious and demanding affection closer to that of a young child's relationship to their parents. This self-regarding love befits liberal individualism rather than mutual solidarity. The ubiquity of both dating apps and multiple partners is one outcome of this process, remaking the cursory and transactional relationship style of youth into an enduring adult norm.

Such self-orientation exists in tension with what we know about the potential of love both from our own experience and in the broader sweep of human culture. Real love makes no account of benefits and losses; rather, it demands the mutual exchange of absolute regard, joyfully saying "You matter more to me than myself!" It's only through this intimacy of care and emotion that we can hope to achieve the kind of epistemic intimacy – the true knowing of and by another – that allows us to escape the solitude that our existence as discrete physical beings entails. This insight is an old one: even the love of God – that ultimate love – consists in such intimate knowledge, according to Saint Paul: "Now we see but a poor reflection as in a mirror; then we shall see face to face. Now I know in part; then I shall know fully, even as I am fully known" (1 Corinthians 13:12).

Source: *Towards Love*, by George Mason, *Philosophy Now*
Words: 482 | **Sentences:** 17 | **Average Words per Sentence:** 28.4 | **Flesch-Kincaid Grade Level:** 15.5

LESSON HANDOUT

Paragraph-wise Understanding (The Doodles)

This passage can look intimidating because a lot of terms are thrown at you: capitalism, labour movement, post-war consensus, liberal individualism, patrilineal property descent, epistemic intimacy. If you sit and unpack every term in full philosophical depth, you will die in the exam hall. We do not need that. We need the **key idea** of each paragraph.

Paragraph 1

The author begins with a basic human problem. We are physical beings. We feel things, think things, experience ourselves inwardly. But when we try to communicate all this to another person, words fail us. Words are ambiguous and imperfect. They do not give the other person a clean window into our inner world.

Doodle:
Communication through words = imperfect

Paragraph 2

Now the author says that love tries to solve that problem. But love can do so only if we treat each other as ends, not as means. Once love becomes transactional, once it becomes about personal gain, benefit, exchange, or "what do I get out of this?", it stops being fully human. The author connects this transactional logic with capitalism and also points out that marriage has historically often operated in such instrumental ways.

Doodle:
Love can solve the problem, but not if it becomes transactional

Paragraph 3

Now the author brings in the labour movement and post-war prosperity. The argument is that the loss of material stability created a social condition in which love itself became more childish, self-regarding, and immature. Dating apps and multiple partners are presented as outcomes of this larger process, not as the original cause of it.

Doodle:
Economic decline → love becomes childish / self-focused / transactional

Paragraph 4

The author now gives the ideal of real love. Real love is not transactional. It is absolute regard. It is the true knowing of and by another person. That is how we escape our solitude as physical beings. This is then extended to the love of God, which is presented as the ultimate example of this kind of intimate knowledge.

Doodle:
Real love = true knowing of each other; no transaction

What the passage is broadly saying

If we simplify the full passage, the movement is something like this:

- Human communication is imperfect.
- Love can remedy this.
- But love cannot do that if it becomes transactional.
- Modern material and social conditions have pushed love toward a childish, self-regarding, transactional form.
- Real love is the opposite: mutual regard and true knowing of another.

That is more than enough understanding to answer the questions. We do not need to become George Mason's research assistant.

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LESSON HANDOUT

Beware of the Sidetracks

- Modern material and social conditions have pushed love toward a childish, self-regarding, transactional form.
- Real love is the opposite: mutual regard and true knowing of another.

That is more than enough understanding to answer the questions. We do not need to become George Mason's research assistant.

LESSON HANDOUT

BEWARE OF THE SIDETRACKS

Question 1

Which of the following is the author most likely to agree with?

(1) Because words are limited, marriage became a practical arrangement.
(2) The decline of trade unions changed the nature of divine love.
(3) Being fully known by another person depends on post-war prosperity.
(4) When love becomes a transaction, it stops feeling deeply human.

- **The Logic:** This is an **author agreement** question. The demand is broad and open. The author has taken many positions in the passage. So the right answer can come from anywhere in the passage, but it must still be something the author would clearly endorse. In such open questions, Sidetrack Type 2 often works through **false connection**. The setter takes ideas from different paragraphs and forces a relation between them.
- **The Passage Evidence:** Paragraph 1 says words are imperfect. Paragraph 2 says love should not be transactional and that marriage has historically often been instrumental. Paragraph 3 connects economic decline with a self-regarding form of love. Paragraph 4 says real love is true knowing of another and not a transactional bargain.
- **The Anticipated Answer:** The author's strongest moral position is clear: when love becomes transactional, it loses its humanity. So I should expect an answer somewhere in that zone.

Option 1: Because words are limited, marriage became a practical arrangement.

Logic (Sidetrack Type 2 – False Connection): This is a false connection. "Words are imperfect" comes from Paragraph 1. "Marriage has often followed instrumentalist contours" comes from Paragraph 2. But the passage never says that imperfect language caused marriage to become practical or instrumental. Those are two different ideas from two different parts of the passage. The setter has forced a causal connection between them. That connection does not exist in the passage. So this is a Sidetrack created by false connection.

Option 2: The decline of trade unions changed the nature of divine love.

Logic (Sidetrack Type 2 – False Connection): Another false connection. The labour movement and post-war prosperity are discussed in Paragraph 3. Divine love appears in Paragraph 4 as an old, ideal example of true love. The passage never says that economic change altered the nature of divine love. Paragraph 3 is about modern adult love becoming self-regarding. Paragraph 4 is about the timeless ideal of love. The option picks one idea from Paragraph 3 and another from Paragraph 4 and ties them together with the word "changed". The passage does not make that link. Sidetrack.

Option 3: Being fully known by another person depends on post-war prosperity.

Logic (Sidetrack Type 2 – False Connection): Again, a forced connection. "Being fully known" comes from Paragraph 4 through the idea of epistemic intimacy. "Post-war prosperity" comes from Paragraph 3 as a material basis for working-class stability. The author does say that material decline has damaged adult love. But the author never says that true knowing itself *depends on* post-war prosperity. That is a much stronger, false dependence claim. The option takes two genuine ideas and welds them together with "depends on." That connection is not passage-truth. Sidetrack.

Option 4: When love becomes a transaction, it stops feeling deeply human.

Correct Answer: This is exactly what the author is saying in Paragraph 2. The passage explicitly describes transactional love as adhering to "inhuman logic" and says that love reduced to pure transaction leads to alienation. This option is a clean paraphrase of that idea. No forced connection. No twist. Just a truthful conversion of the passage idea.

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LESSON HANDOUT

Question 2

The phrase "the sociocultural extension of adolescence" in the passage most nearly suggests that:

conversion of the passage idea.

Question 2

The phrase "the sociocultural extension of adolescence" in the passage most nearly suggests that:

(1) weak labour unions have made people delay marriage for longer.
(2) economic decline has made adult love more childish and self-focused.
(3) dating apps have made adults behave more like young children.
(4) limited language has made adult relationships less emotionally mature.

- **The Logic:** This is a **contextual meaning** question. We need to understand what that phrase means in the immediate context of Paragraph 3. Again, the danger here is false connection. The setter will pick other real ideas from the passage and attach them to the phrase wrongly.
- **The Passage Evidence:** Paragraph 3 says that the erosion of working-class prosperity is mirrored in the sociocultural extension of adolescence, which is then explained as the decline of love as mature commitment and its replacement by capricious, demanding affection closer to a young child's relationship to parents. It also says dating apps are an **outcome** of this process. That word matters. Outcome, not cause.
- **The Anticipated Answer:** The phrase must mean something like this: material decline has made adult love immature, childish, and self-regarding.

Option 1: weak labour unions have made people delay marriage for longer.

Logic (Sidetrack Type 2 – False Connection): Labour movement decline is indeed there in Paragraph 3. But delaying marriage is not the meaning of "extension of adolescence." The phrase is not about age or timing. It is about the *quality* of love becoming childish and immature. So the setter has picked the labour-union idea correctly, but then twisted the consequence into "delay marriage for longer." That is not what the passage says. Sidetrack.

Option 2: economic decline has made adult love more childish and self-focused.

Correct Answer: This captures the meaning beautifully. "Economic decline" is an implied truth from the erosion of working-class gains and prosperity. "More childish and self-focused" is a paraphrase of the author's description of adult love becoming capricious, demanding, and self-regarding, like a young child's relationship to parents. This is the right answer.

Option 3: dating apps have made adults behave more like young children.

Logic (Sidetrack Type 2 – False Connection): This is a really good trap. The paragraph mentions dating apps and also mentions love becoming more childlike. So the option feels tempting. But the passage says dating apps are an **outcome** of the process, not the cause of it. The author's actual causal chain is: economic decline → immature self-regarding love → dating apps as one outcome. This option reverses that. It makes dating apps the cause of childish love. That causal connection is false. Sidetrack.

Option 4: limited language has made adult relationships less emotionally mature.

Logic (Sidetrack Type 2 – False Connection): "Limited language" comes from Paragraph 1. Emotional immaturity in love comes from Paragraph 3. There is no causal link between the two in the passage. The author does not say that our emotional immaturity in relationships comes from the inadequacy of words. The setter has dragged a real idea from Paragraph 1 and forced it into Paragraph 3's argument. Sidetrack.

Question 3

In the passage, God's love is described as one where:

(1) human beings matter more than God.
(2) you are fully understood.
(3) love becomes a reflection of self-love.
(4) loving people is like loving a saint.

LESSON HANDOUT

Question 3

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(1) human beings matter more than God.
(2) you are fully understood.
(3) love becomes a reflection of self-love.
(4) loving people is like loving a saint.

- **The Logic:** This is a **specific detail** question. The author uses God's love as an example in Paragraph 4. We just need to understand exactly what that example is being used to illustrate. This is where Sidetrack Type 2 often works through **twists**. The setter lifts a phrase from somewhere nearby and twists it.
- **The Passage Evidence:** Paragraph 4 says that the love of God consists in intimate knowledge. Then Saint Paul is quoted: "Now I know in part; then I shall know fully, even as I am fully known." So God's love is being used as the ultimate example of true knowing and being fully known.
- **The Anticipated Answer:** Something along the lines of: in God's love, you are fully known / fully understood.

Option 1: human beings matter more than God.

Logic (Sidetrack Type 2 – Twist): This is a twist. The phrase "You matter more to me than myself!" appears earlier in Paragraph 4 as part of the description of real love between persons. The setter has lifted "matter more" and twisted it into a hierarchy between humans and God. The passage never makes such a claim. So this is not a paraphrase. It is a twisted reuse of a nearby idea. Sidetrack.

Option 2: you are fully understood.

Correct Answer: The phrase "I shall know fully, even as I am fully known" is clearly pointing toward complete understanding, complete knowing. "Fully understood" is a neat paraphrase of being fully known. This is exactly what God's love is being used to illustrate.

Option 3: love becomes a reflection of self-love.

Logic (Sidetrack Type 2 – Twist / Lie): Another twist. The passage attacks self-regarding love in Paragraph 3. The quote in Paragraph 4 uses the word "reflection" in the mirror metaphor. The setter has lifted the idea of "self" from Paragraph 3 and "reflection" from Paragraph 4 and stitched them together into nonsense. That is not what the passage says. A beautifully evil twist. Sidetrack.

Option 4: loving people is like loving a saint.

Logic (Sidetrack Type 2 – Twist / Alien Flavour): Saint Paul is mentioned only as the quoted authority. The passage does not say that loving people is like loving a saint, nor does it say saints are the object of love here. The setter uses the presence of Saint Paul to give the option a theological smell and hopes you will mark it. But the idea is not in the passage. Sidetrack by twist.

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LESSON HANDOUT

Question 4

It can be inferred from the passage that the author has reservations about each of the following EXCEPT:

(1) liberal individualism.
(2) patrilineal property descent.
(3) post-war consensus.
(4) the logic of capitalism.

LESSON HANDOUT

Question 4

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(3) post-war consensus.
(4) the logic of capitalism.

- **The Logic:** This is an **inference EXCEPT** question. Three of the options must be things the author dislikes or critiques. One must be something the author does **not** have reservations about. So we are looking for the "safe" option.
- **The Passage Evidence**
  The author clearly attacks:
  - the logic of capitalism
  - instrumental marriage
  - patrilineal property descent
  - liberal individualism

  But the author speaks positively of the material basis of prosperity under the post-war consensus and criticizes the gutting of the labour movement that destroyed it. So the post-war consensus is not something the author is attacking.
- **The Anticipated Answer:** The one thing the author does **not** seem to dislike is the **post-war consensus**.

Option 1: liberal individualism.

Not the answer. The author clearly has reservations about it. In Paragraph 3, self-regarding love "befits liberal individualism rather than mutual solidarity." That is not praise. That is criticism. So the author definitely has reservations here.

Option 2: patrilineal property descent.

Not the answer. Paragraph 2 presents this as part of the instrumental, dehumanizing history of marriage, where wives are reduced to vessels of patrilineal property descent. That is clearly something the author is critical of. Reservations? Absolutely.

Option 3: post-war consensus.

Correct Answer. The author describes the post-war consensus as the period under which working-class prosperity had a material basis: stable jobs, living standards, homes, family life. The author is angry at the **erosion** of these things, which means the author values them. If I am angry that something good was destroyed, I obviously do not have reservations about the thing itself. So this is the EXCEPT.

Option 4: the logic of capitalism.

Not the answer. Paragraph 2 explicitly says that reducing intimacy to a transactional exchange of benefits is reducing it to the logic of capitalism, and that such a relationship adheres to inhuman logic. That is very clear criticism. Reservations? Massive ones.

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LESSON HANDOUT

WHAT THIS LESSON IS REALLY TEACHING

Sidetrack Type 2 works in two major ways:

1. False Connection

The setter picks two real ideas from the passage and forces a relationship between them:

- X caused Y

Correct Answer. The author describes the post-war consensus as the period under which working-class prosperity had a material basis: stable jobs, living standards, homes, family life. The author is angry at the **erosion** of these things, which means the author values them. If I am angry that something good was destroyed, I obviously do not have reservations about the thing itself. So this is the EXCEPT.

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LESSON HANDOUT

WHAT THIS LESSON IS REALLY TEACHING

Sidetrack Type 2 works in two major ways:

1. False Connection

The setter picks two real ideas from the passage and forces a relationship between them:

- X caused Y
- X changed Y
- Y depends on X

The passage never made that connection.

2. Twists

The setter picks a real idea, keeps most of it intact, but adds a small twist that changes the meaning. The words feel familiar, but the thought is no longer the author's thought.

That is why Sidetrack Type 2 is so dangerous. It works not by bringing in something obviously alien, but by using passage-material in the wrong way.

What you must do while solving

First, read the passage slowly enough to understand the key ideas. If the passage is blurry in your head, every familiar option will look right.

Second, when you see an option with connectors like:

- because
- changed
- depends on
- made
- led to
- caused

be very careful. These words are often the site of forced connection.

Third, when an option feels very familiar, do not trust the feeling. Check whether the exact idea and the exact relation are present in the passage.

Fourth, remember: you do not have to label every error as "scope," "alien," "twist," or "false connection" while solving. That is not the point. The point is to detect the distortion.

Module: Know the Question Stems – RC
Lesson 1.2: THE GLOBAL–LOCAL–LOGICAL MAP

Where We Are

Three modules. Three layers of the same skill.

- Module 1 — *Reading Better* — taught you how to read. Doodling, key ideas, paragraph-wise understanding.
- Module 2 — *Killing the Options* — taught you how truth and distortion behave inside options. The S.T.E.A.L.S. framework.

Now comes
Module 3 — *Know the Question Stems.*
This is the bridge between the two. You know how to read. You know how to evaluate options. But each question has a specific **demand** — and knowing that demand shapes where you look, what you anticipate, and which distortions to watch for.

This lesson is the orientation. Before going deep on individual question types, we need the full map.

The Dataset

CAT 2017 to CAT 2025. Every RC passage. Every RC question. Every slot.

- **102 passages**
- **438 questions**
- **24 slots across 9 years**

One thing to know before reading the data: the paper format changed across years.

- 2017–2019: 2 slots × 24 questions = 48 per year
- 2021–2025: 3 slots × 16 questions = 48 per year
- 2020 (IIM Indore, transitional): 3 slots × 18 questions = 54 that year

That is why 2020 reads slightly higher in raw numbers. The percentages normalise across all years and are what we use throughout.

LESSON HANDOUT

The Three Broad Buckets

Every RC question falls into one of three categories.

Bucket	Questions	Share	The Core Ask
Global	50	11.4%	Big picture — main idea, purpose, tone
Local	112	25.6%	Information recall — closed or open
Logical	276	63.0%	Reason beyond retrieval

Global — 50 Qs — 11.4%

Global questions ask about the whole passage — not a detail, not a paragraph in isolation.

- What is the central idea?
- What is the passage trying to do?
- What is the tone?

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Global questions ask about the whole passage — not a detail, not a paragraph in isolation.

- What is the central idea?
- What is the passage trying to do?
- What is the tone?

If you have doodled the passage properly, you have already answered this question before you even read it.

The main distortion here is the sidetrack — a real, true idea from the passage that is secondary rather than central. The passage has many ideas. Every one of them can become a wrong option. The correct answer has to account for the *whole* passage, not just a part.

Local — 112 Qs — 25.6%

Local questions are about information that is explicitly stated in the passage. The challenge is not inference — it is knowing where things are. Local questions come in two forms.

- **Closed:** The question points you to one place — a specific name, concept, or event. You go there, you confirm.
- **Open:** No signal. The answer could be anywhere. Four options, four possible locations.

The closed variety is manageable because you know your destination.
The open variety — especially in the EXCEPT format — needs method. That is the dedicated lesson.

Logical — 276 Qs — 63.0%

Nearly two-thirds of all CAT RC questions are logical.

That number always surprises students. But "logical" does not mean difficult. It simply means the question asks for one more step beyond pure retrieval:

- deriving an implied truth,
- interpreting a phrase,
- identifying the author's stance,
- explaining why an element was used,
- or applying the author's logic to a new situation.

Seven distinct question types live here. Knowing the demand of each is what makes these questions tractable.

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LESSON HANDOUT

The Year-wise Story: Global / Local / Logical

This is the data behind the bar chart from the lesson.

Year	Institute	Global	Local	Logical
2017	IIM Lucknow	19%	44%	37%

LESSON HANDOUT

The Year-wise Story: Global / Local / Logical

This is the data behind the bar chart from the lesson.

Year	Institute	Global	Local	Logical
2017	IIM Lucknow	19%	44%	37%
2018	IIM Kolkata	8%	36%	56%
2019	IIM Kozhikode	6%	16%	78%
2020	IIM Indore	11%	22%	67%
2021	IIM Ahmedabad	17%	21%	62%
2022	IIM Bangalore	13%	12%	75%
2023	IIM Lucknow	4%	31%	65%
2024	IIM Kolkata	8%	29%	62%
2025	IIM Kozhikode	17%	18%	64%

- Logical questions have dominated every single year.
- 2017 is the only year where all three buckets were roughly balanced.
- In 2019, IIM Indore pushed logical questions to 78% — nearly four in every five questions.
- 2022 (IIM Bangalore) was similarly heavy at 75%.

The IIM rotation pattern matters here. Based on it, Indore is likely next for 2026. The 2019 Indore paper leaned heavily on inference and meaning-in-context questions. That is not a guarantee, but it is useful context.

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LESSON HANDOUT

The Nine Question Types

Within the three broad buckets, there are nine specific question types. All 438 questions belong to one of these nine.

#	Type	Bucket	Qs	Share
1	Global	Global	50	11.4%

LESSON HANDOUT

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Within the three broad buckets, there are nine specific question types. All 438 questions belong to one of these nine.

#	Type	Bucket	Qs	Share
1	Global	Global	50	11.4%
2	Local – Closed	Local	48	11.0%
3	Local – Open	Local	64	14.6%
4	Inference	Logical	100	22.8%
5	Meaning in Context	Logical	41	9.4%
6	Author Agreement	Logical	30	6.8%
7	Specific Function	Logical	34	7.8%
8	Strengthen / Weaken	Logical	52	11.9%
9	Application	Logical	19	4.3%
	Total		**438**	**100%**

Each type gets a dedicated lesson. Here is the orientation.

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LESSON HANDOUT

1. Global — 50 Qs — 11.4%

The Demand: Identify the big picture — what the whole passage (or a unit of it) is doing.

The global question asks for the central idea, the primary purpose, the tone, the main idea of one paragraph, or the

LESSON HANDOUT

1. Global — 50 Qs — 11.4%

The Demand: Identify the big picture — what the whole passage (or a unit of it) is doing.

 The global question asks for the central idea, the primary purpose, the tone, the main idea of one paragraph, or the keywords that best map the passage. Your doodle has already answered this. By the time you arrive at a global question, the thinking is largely done.

How the question is framed:

- *The central idea of this passage is that:*
- *Which one of the following best describes what the passage is trying to do?*
- *Which one of the following statements best captures the sense of the first paragraph?*
- *Which one of the following sets of terms best serves as keywords to the passage?*
- *The tone of the passage could best be described as:*

The main trap is the sidetrack — a true idea from the passage that is not the *central* idea. Always ask: does this option account for the *whole* passage, or only a part of it?

2. Local – Closed — 48 Qs — 11.0%

The Demand: Retrieve one specific fact or detail directly stated in one place.

The question tells you what to look for — a specific person, concept, event, or claim. That is your pointer. Your doodle tells you roughly where it lives. Go to that paragraph, confirm, and evaluate the options. You do not always need to re-read; your key idea may already be enough. But going back costs nothing because you know exactly where you are going.

How the question is framed:

- *According to the passage, early Chinese maps placed north at the top because:*
- *The author claims that omitting mention of Indians who served in the Second World War is:*
- *Data provided by Cassini challenged the assumption that:*
- *According to the passage, colonial powers located their capitals:*
- *According to the passage, who or what was an 'alienist'?*

Main distortions: sidetracks from other paragraphs, alien ideas that sound plausible but are not there.

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LESSON HANDOUT

3. Local – Open — 64 Qs — 14.6%

The Demand: Verify facts across the whole passage — no specific location is pointed to.

 This is where the EXCEPT format almost always appears. *"All of the following are true EXCEPT."* Three options are genuine truths drawn from different parts of the passage. One is the distortion. The reason question setters use this format so often is structural: a setter has a passage with five paragraphs and only four questions to create. The EXCEPT format lets a single question cover multiple paragraphs — one option from Paragraph 2, one from Paragraph 3, one

3. Local – Open — 64 Qs — 14.6%

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How the question is framed:

- *All of the following statements are true EXCEPT:*
- *The passage makes all of the following claims EXCEPT:*
- *Which one of the following statements is NOT supported by the passage?*
- *Which of the following does not contribute to the passage's claim about the authorship of Aladdin?*
- *Which one of the following statements is not true about the camouflaging ability of Cephalopods?*

Do not brute-force these. Do not re-read the entire passage for every option. A method for handling open questions is built in the dedicated lesson.

4. Inference — 100 Qs — 22.8% — Largest Type

The Demand: Derive the implied truth from the passage. Reason one step beyond what is stated.

Inference is the largest question type — nearly one in four questions. A word of caution on the label: "inference" is applied loosely here. Some questions use the word *inferred* but are effectively local questions — the answer is directly stated. Others require you to genuinely build the answer from what the passage implies. The approach is the same either way: understand the key idea, anticipate, evaluate.

How the question is framed:

- *It can be inferred from the passage that European explorers like Columbus and Magellan:*
- *The 'long pedigree' of the aim to shift civil servants to improve living standards implies that:*
- *Which one of the following observations is a valid conclusion to draw from the statement, 'From out of the primal darkness...'?*
- *In the context of the passage, which one of the following conclusions CANNOT be reached?*
- *The author believes that the new ruling class betrayed the principles of the French Revolution. Which statement is the likeliest explanation?*

Inference can be closed (the question points you to a specific part of the passage) or open (scope is the whole text). In either case, when stuck: ask what is *true* based on the passage. That is the answer.

5. Meaning in Context — 41 Qs — 9.4%

either case, when stuck: ask what is *true* based on the passage. That is the answer.

5. Meaning in Context — 41 Qs — 9.4%

The Demand: What does this specific word, phrase, or sentence mean *here* — in this passage, in this context?

 This is not a vocabulary question. You do not need external knowledge. The passage gives you everything you need. The setter chose this element because it is doing something interesting — carrying a figurative meaning, making a surprising claim, or doing conceptual work connected to the key idea. That is the signal: it is never a random word. Go to that paragraph, understand how the element is being used in the flow of the argument, and then evaluate the options.

How the question is framed:

- *In paragraph 4, the phrase 'the fabric of elephant society has effectively been frayed by…' is:*
- *'No amount of social analysis can account fully for the existence of Michelangelo or Leonardo.' Which interpretation is most accurate?*
- *The word 'topophobia' in the passage is used:*
- *'Why toil away as a starving peasant when a successful pirate made up to £4,000 on each raid?' The author's tone can best be described as:*
- *The word 'instantiation' is used in paragraph 1. Which pair of terms would be the best substitute for it in context?*

6. Author Agreement — 30 Qs — 6.8%

The Demand: What does the author actually think, support, or oppose?

The key principle: *author stance is passage stance.* We know nothing about the author beyond what the text gives us. Do not project. Do not invent. This question type tends to appear in analytical and argumentative passages — where the author has a clear position or recommendation. In purely expository passages, where the author is presenting without taking sides, there is little stance to extract and this question type rarely appears.

How the question is framed:

- *Based on this extract, the author would support which one of the following actions?*
- *At a conference on folk forms, the author is least likely to agree with which one of the following views?*
- *The author critiques Schiller's approach to behavioural economics for:*
- *The author sees the rise of Netflix in Europe as:*
- *A fundamental conclusion by the author is that:*

The internal demand varies across these framings — some are really main idea questions, some are inference questions, some are application questions. The dedicated lesson unpacks each variant.

LESSON HANDOUT

7. Specific Function — 34 Qs — 7.8%

The Demand: WHY did the author use this element? Always structural job — not content.

 An author gives an example to support a claim. A metaphor to illustrate a point. A reference to establish an idea. The specific function question asks *why* — what job is this element doing? The answer is never *what* the element says. It is always *what claim it is supporting*. That claim will be in the passage, usually right before or after the element. Your doodle captures the key idea of every paragraph. Since examples always serve those key ideas, the answer is usually already in your hands.

How the question is framed:

- *Why does the author say in paragraph 2, 'the massive distribution centres Amazon has opened, often not too far from malls the company helped shutter'?*
- *The author mentions Tanzania's Hadza community to illustrate:*
- *'It's a bit like fuel use in a car. Just because I'm using more fuel doesn't mean I'm going faster…' What is the purpose of this example?*
- *The passage uses the metaphor of a dog walker to argue that evolutionary adaptation is most comprehensively understood as:*
- *Carrier, Babbage, and Edison are mentioned in the passage to illustrate the author's point that:*

Main trap: options that tell you *what* the example says rather than *why* it was placed there.

8. Strengthen / Weaken — 52 Qs — 11.9%

The Demand: New hypothetical evidence is given. Does it support the argument, attack it, or bypass it?

Every argument rests on an assumption — something necessary for the argument to hold that is not explicitly stated. Strengthen and weaken questions test your ability to find that assumption and evaluate new evidence against it. To strengthen: plug the gap, confirm the assumption. To weaken: attack it. To bypass: be irrelevant to it entirely.

How the question is framed:

- *Which of the following, if found to be true, would negate the main message of the passage?*
- *Which one of the following statements, if false, could be seen as supporting the arguments in the passage?*
- *Which one of the assumptions below is most necessary for that suggestion to hold?*
- *Which one of the following observations would most strengthen the passage's claim that a first-order tail event raises the probability of further tail events?*
- *The author's conclusions about the most 'creative cities' in the US are based on his assumption that:*

Watch out for double-negative framings — *"if false, supports"* — which appear in this question type more than any other. Converting those framings cleanly is what the **next lesson** is about.

9. Application — 19 Qs — 4.3% — Rarest Type

The Demand: A new external scenario is given. Export the author's underlying logic and apply it.

This is different from inference. Inference asks what the passage implies. Application asks you to take the author's underlying principle and apply it to a situation that was never in the passage. To do that well, you need the *general logic* the author is working from — not just the specific claims. The setter introduces a new brand, a new person, a new scenario, and asks what the author would think about it. The trap is options that match surface features of the new scenario to surface features of the passage without genuinely applying the author's principle.

How the question is framed:

- *A new food brand plans to launch a series of products in the American market. Which of the following product plans is most likely to be supported by the author?*
- *A French ethnographer decides to study the culture of a Nigerian tribe. Which of the following is most likely to be the view of the author?*
- *In which one of the following scenarios would the cuttlefish's behaviour demonstrate self-control?*
- *If the author of the passage were to write a book on the Battle of Hastings, the focus of the historical account would be on:*

These questions are rare because they take the most intelligence to set. When they appear, the reading you already did gives you everything you need.

The Year × Type Heatmap

How all nine types were distributed across each year. Read across a row to see one year's character. Read down a column to see how one type has varied over time.

LESSON HANDOUT

The Year × Type Heatmap

How all nine types were distributed across each year. Read across a row to see one year's character. Read down a column to see how one type has varied over time.

Year	G	LC	LO	Inf	MiC	AA	SF	S/W	App
2017	19%	25%	19%	4%	4%	4%	23%	2%	—
2018	8%	17%	19%	10%	10%	13%	8%	13%	2%
2019	6%	8%	8%	21%	17%	8%	6%	17%	8%
2020	11%	13%	9%	24%	9%	11%	4%	15%	4%
2021	17%	4%	17%	25%	6%	6%	6%	13%	6%
2022	13%	2%	10%	48%	15%	2%	—	8%	2%
2023	4%	10%	21%	23%	2%	6%	13%	15%	6%
2024	8%	8%	21%	29%	13%	8%	4%	8%	—
2025	17%	10%	8%	21%	8%	2%	6%	17%	10%
Total	**11.4%**	**11.0%**	**14.6%**	**22.8%**	**9.4%**	**6.8%**	**7.8%**	**11.9%**	**4.3%**

G = Global · LC = Local Closed · LO = Local Open · Inf = Inference · MiC = Meaning in Context · AA = Author Agreement · SF = Specific Function · S/W = Strengthen/Weaken · App = Application ·

A few things worth noting from the data.

- Inference has been the dominant type in almost every year — in 2022 (IIM Bangalore), it was 48% of the entire paper.
- 2017 (IIM Lucknow had an unusual 23% share of Specific Function questions, which has not been repeated since.
- Strengthen and Weaken has appeared in every single year without exception.
- Application questions appeared in 7 of 9 years — rare but persistent.
- No question type has been entirely absent across the full dataset.

*That last point is the practical takeaway: **prepare for all nine.** The distribution shifts year to year. Your job is not to predict which type will dominate — it is to recognise any question the moment you see it, understand its demand, and know how to move.*

VARC1000
by Cejo Sreenivasan

LESSON HANDOUT

The Only Thing That Matters

After all this data, one principle sits underneath everything.

The answer is always in the passage.
Not sometimes. Not usually. Always.

No question in these 438 asks you to think beyond the passage.
No question rewards external knowledge or personal opinion.

The passage is the source of truth, and everything you need is there.

- No question type has been entirely absent across the full dataset.

*That last point is the practical takeaway: **prepare for all nine.** The distribution shifts year to year. Your job is not to predict which type will dominate — it is to recognise any question the moment you see it, understand its demand, and know how to move.*

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What this module builds is simple: you see the question type, you know the demand, you know how to anticipate the answer, and you evaluate options by how well they match the passage.

The nine lessons that follow will go deep on each type. The broad strategy does not change. What changes is knowing what to look for — and that is exactly what this module is here to give you.

Module: Know the Question Stems – RC
Lesson 1.3: Dealing with Weird Question Stems

This module's lessons focus on the question itself — what it requires, what evidence you need, and how the answer space should appear. In the coming days, we will explore each question type in detail.

However, this lesson is a bit different. It doesn't focus on the passage, the author's thoughts, or your reading approach. Instead, it's about a particular form of sabotage that question setters sometimes use: **weird framing.**

Since we'll be encountering these weird framings in the upcoming lessons, let's address them early on.

The Weird Framing

The expected: You have a passage. You have a question. You have four options.
Your job, almost always, is simple: find the truth.
The correct option is some version of a truth in the passage; the three wrong ones are distortions.

Most stems make this obvious. You see things like:
- Which of the following is the main idea of the passage?
- Which one of the following will the author agree with?
- What can be inferred from the passage?
- Why did the author use this example?

In all of these, you walk in looking for the truth and pick the option that carries it.

A few unexpected: Some stems flip the instruction. Now you're hunting the distortion—the option that does *not* agree with the passage.
Stems like:
- Which of the following is NOT true?
- Each of the following is true EXCEPT.
- With which of the following would the author DISAGREE?

Here, three options are truths and your job is to spot the one that isn't. Usually, this switch is easy. A single NOT or EXCEPT sits in the stem; you register it, flip your search, and move on.

Then there are the weird ones: They stack negatives on negatives. You get things like:
- Which of the following is not an invalid conclusion based on the passage?
- None of the following is true based on the passage EXCEPT.
- All of the following, if found to be false, would be seen as contradicting the passage, EXCEPT.

Now you're sitting there trying to figure out which way is up. Truth? Distortion? And none of this has anything to do with the passage. It's just framing.

That's what this lesson is for. We're NOT going to decode these stems by reading them carefully. We're going to COUNT.

LESSON HANDOUT

The Only Trick You Need: Count the Negatives

This lesson is a hack. Normally, in this course, I don't like handing out hacks. The course is built around thinking, structure, logic, and passage engagement.

But this specific problem does not reward thinking. It rewards **counting**. So that is what we will do.

Here is the rule, reduced to its smallest form:

Count of Negatives	Net Sign	What You Are Hunting For
Odd (1, 3, 5, 7...)	Negative	The option that does NOT agree with the passage (the distortion)
Even (2, 4, 6, 8...)	Positive	The option that DOES agree with the passage (the truth)

That is the whole lesson. Everything else is practice.

LESSON HANDOUT

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That is the whole lesson. Everything else is practice.

WHY THIS WORKS — THE MATHS IN ONE GLANCE

Each negative operator carries a value of −1. When you multiply them, the signs behave predictably. Any pair of negatives cancels out. Any leftover negative flips the sign.

Negatives Multiplied	Result	Net Sign
−1	−1	Negative
−1 × −1	+1	Positive
−1 × −1 × −1	−1	Negative
−1 × −1 × −1 × −1	+1	Positive

And the positives? **Ignore them.**
Positives are cute. They do not change the final sign. Only the negatives can flip it.

THE VOCABULARY — WHAT COUNTS, WHAT DOESN'T

Before counting anything, you need to know which words are negatives and which words don't change the sign.

NEGATIVE operators (count them)	POSITIVE words (ignore them)
Meaning 'not': not, none, no **Meaning 'except':** except **Meaning 'wrong/false':** invalid, false, incorrect, invalidate, wrong **Meaning 'oppose/attack':** weaken, contradict, disagree **Other flippers:** opposite, refrain, avoid, fail, unwise (and un- prefixes)	**Meaning 'true':** true, valid, correct **Meaning 'follow':** infer, follow, imply **Meaning 'align':** support, strengthen, agree *These words do nothing to the count.* *They sit politely while the negatives decide the sign.*

Now you have everything you need. Scan the stem. Count the negatives. Apply the rule. Do not sit and translate *"not invalid"* into *"valid"*, then *"not valid"* into *"invalid"*, then let EXCEPT flip it again. That is slow and unreliable. Count.

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LESSON HANDOUT

PART 1: PRACTISING ON STATEMENTS

The pre-session test gave you four plain English statements — no passage, no options, just sentences with multiple negatives buried inside them. We will walk through each one.

Question 1
Choose the option that correctly follows the sentence/instruction:
"Do not choose the idea that is not incorrect."

unwise (and un- prefixes)

Now you have everything you need. Scan the stem. Count the negatives. Apply the rule. Do not sit and translate *"not invalid"* into *"valid"*, then *"not valid"* into *"invalid"*, then let EXCEPT flip it again. That is slow and unreliable. Count.

LESSON HANDOUT

PART 1: PRACTISING ON STATEMENTS

The pre-session test gave you four plain English statements — no passage, no options, just sentences with multiple negatives buried inside them. We will walk through each one.

Question 1
Choose the option that correctly follows the sentence/instruction:
"Do not choose the idea that is not incorrect."
(1) Choose the correct idea
(2) Choose the incorrect idea

"Do not choose the idea that is not incorrect."

Negative Count: 3 | Odd Count | NET SIGN: NEGATIVE
Three negatives collapse into one net negative. The whole sentence is telling you to do something wrong. That something is **choosing the incorrect idea.** The count got you there in three seconds. Unwinding it manually, as you can see, would have taken three separate mental flips.

✓ **Option (2) — Choose the incorrect idea**

Question 2
Choose the option that correctly follows the sentence/instruction:
"It is not unwise to avoid not revising before the test."
(1) Revising before the test is unnecessary
(2) You should revise before the test

"It is not unwise to avoid not revising before the test."

Negative Count: 4 | Even Count | NET SIGN: POSITIVE
Four negatives — two pairs — cancel out entirely. The surface of the sentence looks discouraging (*"avoid"*, *"not revising"*) but the net instruction is a simple one: revise. The count gets you there without any grammar parsing.

✓ **Option (2) — You should revise before the test**

Question 3
Choose the option that correctly follows the sentence/instruction:
"You should not disagree that it is impossible not to notice the change."
(1) The change is noticeable
(2) The change is impossible to notice

"You should not disagree that it is impossible not to notice the change."

Negative Count: 4 | Even Count | NET SIGN: POSITIVE
Four negatives, even count, positive outcome. The sentence is stating that the change **is** noticeable. Option (2) — *"impossible to notice"* — is the exact opposite, which is precisely the kind of trap the question is hoping you fall into if you try to unwind the grammar manually.

✓ **Option (1) — The change is noticeable**

(2) The change is impossible to notice

"You should not disagree that it is impossible not to notice the change."

Negative Count: 4 | Even Count | NET SIGN: POSITIVE
Four negatives, even count, positive outcome. The sentence is stating that the change **is** noticeable. Option (2) — *"impossible to notice"* — is the exact opposite, which is precisely the kind of trap the question is hoping you fall into if you try to unwind the grammar manually.

✓ **Option (1) — The change is noticeable**

Question 4
Choose the option that correctly follows the sentence/instruction:
"Do the opposite of what I say: do not refrain from failing to avoid choosing the option that is not wrong."
(1) Choose the option that is correct
(2) Do not choose the option that is correct

"Do the opposite of what I say: do not refrain from failing to avoid choosing the option that is not wrong."

Negative Count: 7 | Odd Count | NET SIGN: NEGATIVE
Seven negatives. Seven layers of pain. Anyone trying to unwind this manually in exam conditions will either take ninety seconds or get lost halfway through. The count — seven, odd, negative — tells you the entire thing in two seconds. **Do not choose the option that is correct.** That is the answer.

✓ **Option (2) — Do not choose the option that is correct**

PART 1 AT A GLANCE

Q	Statement	Negatives	Count	Net Outcome	Correct Answer
1	"Do not choose the idea that is not incorrect."	not, not, incorrect	3	Negative	Choose the incorrect idea
2	"It is not unwise to avoid not revising before the test."	not, unwise, avoid, not	4	Positive	You should revise before the test
3	"You should not disagree that it is impossible not to notice the change."	not, disagree, impossible, not	4	Positive	The change is noticeable
4	"Do the opposite of what I say: do not refrain from failing to avoid choosing the option that is not wrong."	opposite, not, refrain, failing, avoid, not, wrong	7	Negative	Do not choose the option that is correct

If you can do this on raw sentences, the question stems will feel far easier. The mechanics are identical. Only the vocabulary changes.

LESSON HANDOUT

PART 2: APPLYING THE COUNT TO QUESTION STEMS

Now we move from plain English into actual CAT-style question stems. Each stem is reproduced first, exactly as it appears in the pre-session test — with the two meta-options (what you are supposed to find) and the correct answer. The detailed breakdown follows each.

Two reminders before we begin:

- **Odd count** → find the option that **does not** agree with the passage (the distortion, the attacker).
- **Even count** → find the option that **does** agree with the passage (the truth, the supporter).

And for strengthen/weaken stems: treat **weaken, contradict, invalidate** as negative.
Treat, **strengthen**, and **support** as positive.

Question 5
Question stem:
"Each of the following is true as per the passage EXCEPT"
What you are supposed to find:
(1) The option that agrees with the passage
(2) The option that does not agree with the passage

"Each of the following is true as per the passage EXCEPT"

Negative Count: 1 | Odd Count | NET SIGN: NEGATIVE
One negative, odd count, negative outcome. The stem is asking for the **distortion** — three options are true, one is not, and the EXCEPT points to the not-true one.

✓ **Option (2) — The option that does not agree with the passage**

Question 6
Question stem:
"Each of the following is invalid as per the passage EXCEPT"
What you are supposed to find:
(1) The option that agrees with the passage
(2) The option that does not agree with the passage

"Each of the following is invalid as per the passage EXCEPT"

Negative Count: 2 | Even Count | NET SIGN: POSITIVE
Read this carefully. If the setter had stopped at *"Each of the following is invalid"*, you would have been hunting for the distortion. But the EXCEPT flips it. Three options are invalid; the one that *breaks* the invalid pattern is the valid one — the truth. Two negatives cancel. Back to positive.

✓ **Option (1) — The option that agrees with the passage**

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by Gejo Sreenivasan

LESSON HANDOUT

Question 7

LESSON HANDOUT

Question 7
Question stem:
"None of the following can be inferred from the passage EXCEPT"
What you are supposed to find:
(1) The option that agrees with the passage
(2) The option that does not agree with the passage

"None of the following can be inferred from the passage EXCEPT"

Negative Count: 2 | Even Count | NET SIGN: POSITIVE
Three options cannot be inferred (they are distortions); you want the one exception — the inference that *does* hold. That is the option agreeing with the passage.

✓ **Option (1) — The option that agrees with the passage**

Question 8
Question stem:
"Which of the following, if false, would weaken the passage?"
What you are supposed to find:
(1) The option that agrees with the passage
(2) The option that does not agree with the passage

"Which of the following, if false, would weaken the passage?"

Negative Count: 2 | NET SIGN: POSITIVE
Two negatives, even count, positive outcome. Logically: *"if false, would weaken"* is the same as *"if true, would strengthen."* Same answer. But counting gets you there faster.

✓ **Option (1) — The option that supports the passage**

Question 9
Question stem:
"Which of the following, if false, would strengthen the passage?"
What you are supposed to find:
(1) The option that agrees with the passage
(2) The option that does not agree with the passage

"Which of the following, if false, would strengthen the passage?"

Negative Count: 1 | Odd Count | NET SIGN: NEGATIVE
One negative, odd count, negative outcome. The stem wants you to find an option that, if true, would attack the passage.

✓ **Option (2) — The option that attacks the passage**

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LESSON HANDOUT

Question 10
Question stem:
"Each of the following, if false, would support the passage EXCEPT"
What you are supposed to find:
(1) The option that agrees with the passage
(2) The option that does not agree with the passage

✓ **Option (2) — The option that attacks the passage**

Question 10
Question stem:
"Each of the following, if false, would support the passage EXCEPT"
What you are supposed to find:
(1) The option that agrees with the passage
(2) The option that does not agree with the passage

"Each of the following, if false, would support the passage EXCEPT"

Negative Count: 2 | Even Count | NET SIGN: POSITIVE
Two negatives, even count, positive outcome. The stem wants you to find an option that, if true, would support the passage.

✓ **Option (1) — The option that supports the passage**

Question 11
Question stem:
"All of the following statements, if found to be false, would be seen as contradicting the passage EXCEPT"
What you are supposed to find:
(1) The option that agrees with the passage
(2) The option that does not agree with the passage

"All of the following statements, if found to be false, would be seen as contradicting the passage EXCEPT

This is where the setter shows off. Don't let the length scare you. Just count.
Negative Count: 3 | Odd Count | NET SIGN: NEGATIVE
Three negatives, odd count, negative outcome. The stem wants you to find an option that, if true, would attack the passage.

✓ **Option (2) — The option that attacks the passage**

Question 12
Question stem:
"None of the following statements, if false, would be seen as supporting the passage EXCEPT"
What you are supposed to find:
(1) The option that agrees with the passage
(2) The option that does not agree with the passage

"None of the following statements, if false, would be seen as supporting the passage EXCEPT"

Take this slowly. Every negative counts.
Negative Count: 3 | Odd Count | NET SIGN: NEGATIVE
Three negatives, odd count, negative outcome. The stem wants you to find an option that, if true, would attack the passage.

✓ **Option (2) — The option that attacks the passage**

What you are supposed to find:
(1) The option that agrees with the passage
(2) The option that does not agree with the passage

"None of the following statements, if false, would be seen as supporting the passage EXCEPT"

Take this slowly. Every negative counts.
Negative Count: 3 | Odd Count | NET SIGN: NEGATIVE
Three negatives, odd count, negative outcome. The stem wants you to find an option that, if true, would attack the passage.

✓ **Option (2) — The option that attacks the passage**

PART 2 AT A GLANCE

The whole of Part 2 in one place, ready for revision:

Stem	Negatives	#	The Answer
"Each of the following is true as per the passage EXCEPT"	except	1	DISTORTION
"Each of the following is invalid as per the passage EXCEPT"	invalid, except	2	TRUTH
"None of the following can be inferred from the passage EXCEPT"	none, except	2	TRUTH
"Which of the following, if false, would weaken the passage?"	false, weaken	2	SUPPORTS passage
"Which of the following, if false, would strengthen the passage?"	false	1	ATTACKS passage
"Each of the following, if false, would support the passage EXCEPT"	false, except	2	SUPPORTS passage
"All of the following statements, if found to be false, would be seen as contradicting the passage EXCEPT"	false, contradict, except	3	ATTACKS passage
"None of the following statements, if false, would be seen as supporting the passage EXCEPT"	none, false, except	3	ATTACKS passage

Every weird stem the CAT can throw at you, no matter how ugly the dressing, can be cracked by this count. Do not engage with the grammar. Engage with the operator count.

THE NEGATIVE OPERATORS — YOUR WATCH LIST

Commit this list to memory. When any of these words appears in a question stem, add one to your count.

- **not, none, no**
- **except**
- **invalid, invalidate**
- **false, incorrect, wrong**
- **disagree, contradict**
- **weaken, call into question**

And any similar word that reverses logic. The exact word does not matter. If it flips the meaning, it counts.
Ignore everything else. *True, valid, infer, follow, support, strengthen, agree* — these do not flip anything. They keep the sign unchanged.

If the setter stacks negatives, you stack a count. The moment you see more than one flip-word, do not read the stem — count it.

Ignore everything else. *True, valid, infer, follow, support, strengthen, agree* — these do not flip anything. They keep the sign unchanged.

If the setter stacks negatives, you stack a count. The moment you see more than one flip-word, do not read the stem — count it.

Final Takeaway

This lesson is deliberately mechanical. There is no deep conceptual insight here because the problem itself is not conceptual — it is a grammatical trick. Once you have the count, the trick dies.

- If the count is **even**, you are looking for the option that **does** agree with the passage — the truth, the supporter, the one that fits.
- If the count of negative operators is **odd**, you are looking for the option that **does not** agree with the passage — the distortion, the attacker, the odd one out.
- Do not unwind stems logically under time pressure. Count, decide, move on.

The larger point from this session is a point about **where not to spend your time**.

In a 40-minute VARC section, the wrong place to lose time is a stem you could have cracked in five seconds by counting. The passage deserves your time. The options deserve your time. Stupid framing does not.

Module: Know the Question Stems – RC

Lesson: Global Questions – Part 1

WHERE WE ARE

The previous lesson gave us the full map. Three buckets — Global, Local, Logical. Nine question types inside them. The orientation is done. Now we go deep on the first type on the list.

Global questions. Fifty questions out of 438, across CAT 2017 to 2025. That is 11.4% of the paper — roughly one question out of every nine. Not the biggest type, but the one your doodles are most directly built for.

This lesson and the next one cover Global questions. This one handles the four main subtypes — the ones you will almost certainly see. The next one handles the rarer variants: question types that show up occasionally but behave differently enough to deserve separate treatment.

By the end of this lesson, you should walk away with three things:

- the four subtypes of Global questions that dominate the CAT
- the distortions that trap aspirants, ranked by how often each one actually appears
- a repeatable method for dealing with each subtype

WHAT A GLOBAL QUESTION IS ACTUALLY TESTING

A Global question does not ask you to go anywhere in particular in the passage. It asks you to stand back and see the whole thing at once.

- *What is this passage primarily arguing?*
- *How does the author feel about X?*
- *Which five words best capture the passage?*
- *What is the author trying to do?*

Here is the good news. If you read the passage the way we have been training you to read — doodling each paragraph, tracking the arc, anticipating the destination — you have already done most of the work these questions are asking you to do. By the time a Global question shows up on your screen, the thinking is largely over. What remains is option-discipline.

And that is exactly where the trap lives.

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- *Which five words best capture the passage?*
- *What is the author trying to do?*

Here is the good news. If you read the passage the way we have been training you to read — doodling each paragraph, tracking the arc, anticipating the destination — you have already done most of the work these questions are asking you to do. By the time a Global question shows up on your screen, the thinking is largely over. What remains is option-discipline.

And that is exactly where the trap lives.

THE DISTORTION PROFILE — STEALS IN GLOBAL QUESTIONS

Fifty Global questions. Four options each. Two hundred option slots in total. Fifty of them are correct. One hundred and fifty are distortions. I looked at every one of those 150 across nine years of the CAT and sorted them by STEALS tag. Here is the distribution.

- **Sidetrack — 43%.** A true statement from the passage that does not answer the specific question being asked. This is by far the most common trap in Global questions, and that makes logical sense: the passage is full of truths, and in a Global question the setter only needs *one* of them — the central one. Every other truth can become a wrong option.
- **Tone Mismatch — 19%.** The content is right; the intensity is wrong. The author is mildly critical; the option says he is scathing. The author is appreciative; the option says he is devotional. These turn up especially in Author's Attitude and Purpose questions.
- **Lie — 14%.** A direct contradiction of what the passage says. Less common than you might expect, because crude contradictions are easy to spot.
- **Alien Idea — 11%.** A concept the passage never mentions, quietly slipped in.
- **Extreme — 8%.** Overstatement through *always, never, inevitable, only.*
- **Scope — 5%.** The option expands or narrows the boundaries of the discussion. If the passage talks about India and the option says Asia, that is scope.

The headline number here is the one that should shape your entire approach. More than six out of every ten wrong options in a Global question are either Sidetrack or Tone Mismatch. Train for those two first. The rest are real, but they are rare.

And one last caution that this data makes vivid. Just because an option is *true* does not mean it is the *answer*. That feeling of recognition when you read an option — "yes, I remember reading this" — is exactly the feeling the Sidetrack trap is engineered to produce. Familiarity is not the same as correctness. Hold that line.

THE PASSAGE

VARC1000
by Gejo Sreenivasan

Let us work with a passage. I picked one that has a lot of moving parts — it opens on colonisation, then jumps into Christian theology, then into art, then into Frida Kahlo, then into something called otherness. It looks like four different passages stitched together. That is precisely why it is useful. On a passage with so many distinct ideas, the Sidetrack trap has plenty of material to work with, and you will see how the setters actually build those traps.

Source

Serrato, A.C.; Candiotto, J. d. F. The Kenotic Dimension in the Work of Frida Kahlo: Contributions to Latin American Theology. Religions, 2025.

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Passage Stats

500 words | 19 sentences | 26.3 average words per sentence | Flesch–Kincaid Grade 17.1

The Grade 17.1 number tells you this is graduate-level prose. Long sentences, abstract vocabulary, theological terminology. Do not panic at the abstraction. Keep doing what we have been doing — read for control, not for mastery.

The Text

The Text

The Iberic colonisation (colonisation by Spain and Portugal, the two major European powers) of Latin America began in the 16th century and was firmly established in the 17th century, representing a complex process that deeply affected cultures, societies, and local identities. This was not just a territorial victory, but systemic oppression with the aim of total subjugation of indigenous peoples and imposition of a new cultural, socioeconomic, and economic order. Destruction of original cultures like the Inca and Aztec resulted in significant cultural, social, and populational losses. . . .

Another emblematic element in this context is the practice of implanted Christianity (a version of Christianity introduced and enforced by colonisers, often replacing indigenous belief systems). In this sense, legitimation of extreme forms of exploited human work such as the indigenous encomienda (a Spanish colonial system where indigenous people were compelled to work for colonisers in return for supposed 'protection') or the trafficking and slavery of Africans left eternally unanswered questions regarding the character of implanted Christianity. . . .

Within this broader religious framework, the idea of kenosis, understood in Christian theology as self-emptying through humility and renunciation, is used here to interpret the colonial condition as one in which entire peoples were stripped of their cultural and existential grounding. . . . The exploitation lived by Latin Americans, being stripped of their culture, is thus a thoroughly kenotic experience.

However, it must be emphasised that kenosis is not a static and irreversible process. In this context, different forms of resistance emerged in the attempt to regenerate and reclaim identity, aiming to construct new forms of existence. The work of Frida Kahlo is an example of the consequences of this violent depletion. Her art reflects the physical and emotional damage of colonisation, especially gender, the struggle to reclaim identity, and the search for an existential feeling among this pain and oppression. . . .

From the perspective of kenotic theology, Frida Kahlo's works reflect an experience of emptying through her art. Just as in Christianity, where art leads to the experience of Christ, in Kahlo's work, art also expresses the experience of pain, suffering, and transformation. Art, in this sense, reflects the experience of the artist, her culture, and the reality of the context in which she is inserted, creating a link between personal emptying and artistic manifestation. Frida Kahlo's art and the theology of kenosis are related here based on three main aspects: the emptying of the self, pain as a path to transcendence, and the resignification. . . .

Frida Kahlo's trajectory included exposing suffering through her paintings, visualising the body in pain, and turning the private world public. The whispers of exposed pain show us a path to reclaim dignity in the midst of pain. Thus, art recognises the voices of many other faces that cry out, images that ushered in a time in which otherness breaks through, "they say" and ask us. Therefore, art presents itself as theological insofar as it generates a place where kenosis takes place to open up a space for epiphany and the manifestation of otherness.

otherness.

READING THE PASSAGE, PARAGRAPH BY PARAGRAPH

Paragraph 1 — The wound, stated in historical terms.

The opening paragraph plants the flag. Iberic colonisation of Latin America — beginning 16th century, firmly established by the 17th — is not being described as conquest. The author moves quickly from "territorial victory" to "systemic oppression", from "subjugation" to "destruction of original cultures". The Inca and the Aztec are named. This is a loud, angry opening. The author has a position, and he wants you to know it from sentence one.

Doodle: *Iberic colonisation → destruction of cultures in Latin America.*

Paragraph 2 — The second wound: implanted Christianity.

Another "emblematic element" arrives. This is not Christianity in general — the author is careful. It is *implanted* Christianity, a version introduced and enforced by colonisers to replace indigenous belief systems. That qualifier matters, and it matters now because the passage is about to bring in more Christian theology later. The author's complaint is not with the faith. It is with the way the faith was used — as moral cover for encomienda, slavery, exploitation. Hold that distinction.

Doodle: *Implanted Christianity → exploitation.*

Paragraph 3 — The pivot. A theological concept enters.

This is where the passage becomes difficult for most readers. A word appears — *kenosis* — and it throws people. The author defines it: in Christian theology, kenosis is self-emptying through humility and renunciation. Then he does something with it. He uses kenosis — picks it up as a *lens* — to reinterpret what colonisation did. Latin Americans were stripped of their cultural and existential grounding. That stripping, he says, is a kenotic experience.

Do not get lost here. One thing matters: kenosis is being used as a tool to name the wound. The author is not defending kenotic theology, not attacking it, not explaining its lineage. He is borrowing it. That stance — appreciative, instrumental, constructive — is the stance the passage will maintain throughout. Remember this when the Author's Attitude question arrives.

Doodle: *Colonisation reread as kenosis — a cultural emptying.*

Paragraph 4 — However.

That is the loudest word in the passage, and it earns its position. Kenosis, the author insists, is not static and not irreversible. Resistance emerges. Identity is reclaimed. The work of Frida Kahlo is flagged — and flagged very specifically — as *"an example"* of this reversal. Not the subject. An example. Mark that. If an option later promotes Kahlo from example to subject, that option is wrong.

Doodle: *Kenosis is reversible. Resistance happens. Kahlo's art is an example.*

example to subject, that option is wrong.

Doodle: *Kenosis is reversible. Resistance happens. Kahlo's art is an example.*

Paragraph 5 — The example unpacked.

Now the two threads — kenotic theology and Kahlo's art — are explicitly linked. Just as Christian art leads to the experience of Christ, Kahlo's art expresses pain, suffering, and transformation. Her art and the theology of kenosis are related on three aspects: emptying of the self, pain as a path to transcendence, and resignification. Notice what is happening at the structural level. The author is not just using kenosis to diagnose the wound. He is using it to explain the response to the wound. The concept has become load-bearing.

Doodle: *Kahlo's art enacts kenotic theology.*

Paragraph 6 — Where the passage lands.

The closing paragraph reaches for the destination. Kahlo's trajectory — exposing suffering through painting, turning private pain public — opens a path to reclaim dignity. And then the passage widens. Art, it says, recognises the voices of many other faces. Otherness breaks through. Art itself becomes *theological*, precisely because it generates a space where kenosis takes place — and that space is where the Other is encountered.

If the passage has been confusing so far, this last paragraph is where the point lands. Colonisation was the wound. Kenosis is the frame. Art is the reversal. And through art, we meet the Other.

Doodle: *Art becomes sacred space for otherness.*

THE ARC

Compress the six doodles and you get one movement — three beats long.

- **Wound (Paragraphs 1–3):** colonisation, read as a kenotic emptying.
- **Reversal (Paragraphs 4–5):** resistance, enacted through art, with Kahlo as the example.
- **Destination (Paragraph 6):** the encounter with the Other.

Lock this in. Every Global question on this passage is going to be answered against this three-beat arc. Any option that gives you only the wound is incomplete. Any option that promotes Kahlo from example to subject is distorted. Any option that misreads the author's relationship with kenotic theology is trapped.

THE FOUR SUBTYPES OF GLOBAL QUESTIONS

Four flavours. Different demands. Different traps.

1. **Main Idea.** What is the passage primarily arguing? Watch for Sidetracks.
2. **Author's Attitude.** How does the author feel about X? Watch for Tone Mismatches.
3. **Keyword Mapping.** Which set of words best represents the ideas of the passage? One wrong word kills the option.
4. **Purpose / Function.** What is the author doing? The verb is the test.

We will now go through one question of each type — all drawn from the passage above.

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QUESTION 1 | MAIN IDEA

Which of the following best captures the central idea of the passage?

(1) Iberic colonisation inflicted systemic cultural destruction on Latin America, and implanted Christianity legitimising this exploitation, and the unanswered questions it raised continue to define the region's historical memory.

(2) Kenosis offers a lens to read the colonial stripping of Latin American cultures; the concept illuminates the spiritual dimension of that loss, and it recasts exploitation as a theological as well as a historical event.

(3) Frida Kahlo's art exposes the wounds inflicted by the colonisation of Latin America, transforms private pain into public witness, and recovers personal identity in the face of a violent cultural erasure.

(4) The colonial experience of Latin America can be read as a kenotic emptying, art such as Kahlo's becomes the space where that emptying is resisted, and through such art, the human face of the Other is encountered.

Correct Answer: (4)

Type: Global — Main Idea

The Demand: Find the single option that captures what the passage is primarily arguing — the thread that ties every paragraph together, not just one slice of it.

Anticipate

Collapse the six doodles into the three-beat arc: Wound → Reversal → Destination. That arc is your checklist. The correct option has to move across all three. Any option that describes only the wound is incomplete. Any option that sits inside only the framework is incomplete. Any option that promotes Kahlo from example to subject is incomplete.

One more thing to walk in with. On Main Idea questions, the setter's favourite weapon is the *Sidetrack-truth* — a faithful summary of one slice of the passage, dressed up to look like a summary of the whole. Recognition will feel like correctness. Hold the line. Before you mark any option, ask whether it covers the whole arc or only covers one part of it well.

Kill the Options

Option (1). *Tag — S — Sidetrack (truth that does not answer the question).*

Read this carefully and ask yourself — is anything in it false? No. Colonisation did inflict systemic destruction. Christianity did legitimise exploitation. Those questions are genuinely unanswered. The author would nod along to every word. So where is the problem? This option is a faithful summary of Paragraphs 1 and 2 and nothing else. No kenosis, no reversal, no art, no Kahlo, no Other. Four out of six paragraphs are missing. It is not distorting the passage — it is reciting the wrong part of it. Your brain will go, "yes, I remember reading this," and familiarity will feel like correctness. Do not fall for it.

Option (2). *Tag — S — Sidetrack (truth that does not answer the question).*

Now this one is dangerous, and it will catch the smart students — the ones who correctly identified kenosis as the *big idea* word. The option takes kenosis and describes its function in three elegant doodles. Every one is true. The author does exactly this in Paragraph 3. But the question is not *"what does kenosis do in this passage?"* — it is *"what is this passage primarily arguing?"* Kenosis is a tool the author uses; it is not the thing he is arguing for. Notice what is missing — the "However" of Paragraph 4. This option never turns. It captures the diagnosis in triplicate and walks away before the author makes his actual move.

Option (3). *Tag — S — Sidetrack (truth that does not answer the question).*

This is the option most students will fight hardest to defend, and I will tell you why. Kahlo is vivid. Kahlo is memorable. And this option gives her a clean three-doodle arc — expose, transform, recover. Emotionally satisfying. Factually accurate. Every clause is supported by Paragraphs 4 and 5. But read the passage again. The author himself tells you how to read Kahlo — *"the work of Frida Kahlo is an example of..."*. She is illustrative. She is the case study, not the case. An option that makes Kahlo the subject is answering a different question — *"what does Kahlo's art do?"* — which is a real, answerable question from this passage, just not the one being asked. Notice what quietly vanishes here: kenosis is gone, the Other is gone, the broader theological argument is gone. Do not let a vivid example hijack your reading.

Option (4). *Correct Answer.*

Map the doodles onto the three clauses. First: *the colonial experience of Latin America can be read as a kenotic emptying* — Paragraphs 1, 2, and 3 compressed into a single clause. Wound named through the framework. Second: *art such as Kahlo's becomes the space where that emptying is resisted* — Paragraph 4's "However" and the Kahlo material of Paragraph 5, folded together. Third: *through such art, the human face of the Other is encountered* — Paragraph 6, the closing move. Wound, reversal, destination. Every paragraph is accounted for.

Notice the grammar of this option — this is how you spot a cleanly built correct answer. It does not say the passage is about Kahlo; it says *"art such as Kahlo's"*, keeping her as an example. It does not say colonisation *is* kenosis; it says it *can be read as* kenotic — which is exactly the interpretive move the author makes. No overclaim, no underclaim, no misplaced element. Every word is earned.

VARC1000
by Gejo Sreenivasan

QUESTION 2 | AUTHOR'S ATTITUDE

Which one of the following best describes the author's attitude towards kenotic theology?

(1) He treats kenotic theology as a useful interpretive framework, adopting its core idea and extending it to read both the colonial wound and the artistic response to it.

QUESTION 2 | AUTHOR'S ATTITUDE

Which one of the following best describes the author's attitude towards kenotic theology?

(1) He treats kenotic theology as a useful interpretive framework, adopting its core idea and extending it to read both the colonial wound and the artistic response to it.

(2) He approaches kenotic theology with scholarly detachment, presenting it as one of several possible lenses through which the colonial condition can be examined.

(3) He views kenotic theology with unease, since its Christian origins are entangled with the very colonial project that imposed Christianity on Latin America in the first place.

(4) He embraces kenotic theology as a spiritually profound doctrine and holds it up as a model for how contemporary societies should respond to historical injustice.

Correct Answer: (1)

Type: Global — Author's Attitude

The Demand: Identify, from the way the author uses kenotic theology across the passage, what his stance towards it actually is — not what he says about it explicitly, but what his handling of it reveals.

Anticipate

Attitude is usually not stated. It is performed. So watch what the author does with kenotic theology every time it appears.

- Paragraph 3 — *"the idea of kenosis is used here to interpret..."* Notice the verb. *Used.* He is picking it up as an instrument. He is not defending it, not explaining its theological lineage, not questioning its validity. He is applying it.
- Paragraph 4 — *"kenosis is not a static and irreversible process."* Kenosis in traditional Christian theology is about Christ's self-emptying — a specific doctrinal idea. The author is extending it to include reversal, resistance, cultural recovery. You do not extend a concept you distrust.
- Paragraphs 5 and 6 — kenotic theology becomes the mechanism through which the entire argument about art and the Other operates.

Knit these together. The author picks up kenotic theology, adopts it without critique, trusts it to name a real historical wound, extends it beyond its traditional scope, and makes it the backbone of his argument. He is not a theologian of kenosis — he is a *user* of it. A confident, constructive, appreciative user.

One distinction to hold firmly before you go to the options. The author *is* critical in this passage — but of *implanted Christianity* (Paragraph 2), not of *kenotic theology*. Implanted Christianity is a historical instrument of colonisation. Kenotic theology is a theological concept he is borrowing for his argument. He is hostile to the first, warmly constructive with the second. A trap is going to try to slide the hostility across. Do not let it.

QUESTION 4 | PURPOSE / FUNCTION

Which one of the following best describes what the passage is trying to do?

(1) It documents the destruction inflicted by Iberic colonisation on Latin American cultures and demonstrates the complicity of implanted Christianity in that violence.

(2) It critiques kenotic theology as complicit in colonial violence and proposes art as a secular alternative for addressing historical injustice.

(3) It uses a theological concept to reinterpret colonial suffering as a cultural emptying and presents art as the space where that emptying can be resisted.

(4) It analyses Frida Kahlo's paintings to show how art can transform private suffering into a public witness against colonial violence.

Correct Answer: (3)

Type: Global — Purpose / Function

The Demand: Identify the act the author is performing across the whole passage — not what the passage is about, but what it is doing.

Anticipate

A purpose question is asking about verbs, not nouns. Not *"what is the passage about"* — but *"what is the author doing?"* The whole trick is to find the right verb.

Walk through the passage and name the author's act.

He is not merely *documenting* colonisation. If he stopped at Paragraph 2, that would be all he was doing. But he goes further. He is not *analysing* Kahlo — he uses her as an example, not as a subject of study. He is not *critiquing* kenotic theology — he embraces it, uses it, extends it. Critique would mean holding it up for evaluation and finding fault with it, and he does none of that.

What he is actually doing is this. He picks up a Christian theological concept (kenosis), applies it to a historical wound (colonisation), and argues that art — shown through Kahlo — is where the wound gets pushed back against. The act has three moves: he borrows a theological concept, reinterprets a historical situation through it, and proposes art as the site of response.

The right verb, then, is something like *uses / draws on / reinterprets / reframes*. The right object is *colonial suffering through a theological lens*. And the right destination is *art as the space of resistance*.

Walk into the options looking for that three-part act. Options that describe only one part — only the wound, only Kahlo — are incomplete. Options that use the wrong verb — *critiques* instead of *uses* — are misreading what the author is doing.

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by Gejo Sreenivasan

Kill the Options

Option (1). *Tag — S — Sidetrack.*

Everything this option describes is true. Yes, the author documents colonial destruction. Yes, he shows Christianity's complicity. But look at where the option stops — Paragraph 2. The passage has four more paragraphs after that, and they

Kill the Options

Option (1). *Tag — S — Sidetrack.*

Everything this option describes is true. Yes, the author documents colonial destruction. Yes, he shows Christianity's complicity. But look at where the option stops — Paragraph 2. The passage has four more paragraphs after that, and they are the ones where the real action happens. Kenosis, resistance, art, Kahlo, the Other — none of it is here. This option treats the passage as a history lesson, when the history is only the setup. The verb *documents* is wrong on its own terms too — documenting is what a reporter does, and this author is doing something more than reporting. An option that stops before the argument has missed the act.

Option (2). *Tag — L — Lie.*

Two direct contradictions of what the passage actually does. First, the author does not *critique* kenotic theology — he *uses* it. He makes it the backbone of his interpretation. You do not build your argument on a foundation you think is broken. Second, the author does not propose art as a *secular* alternative to theology — he explicitly argues that art becomes theological. Paragraph 6 says art "presents itself as theological insofar as it generates a place where kenosis takes place." That is the opposite of secular. The verb is wrong, the relationship is wrong, and the alternative it proposes is invented. Reject cleanly.

Option (3). *Correct Answer.*

Check each move. *Uses a theological concept* — yes, he picks up kenosis in Paragraph 3. *To reinterpret colonial suffering* — yes, he reads colonisation as kenotic emptying. *As a cultural emptying* — yes, that is the phrase the passage uses. *Presents art as the space where that emptying can be resisted* — yes, Paragraph 4's "However" and the Kahlo material in Paragraphs 5–6 do exactly this. The verb is right. The object is right. The destination is right. Three-part act captured cleanly. Mark and move.

Option (4). *Tag — S — Sidetrack.*

Same problem as Option 1, from the other end of the passage. Option 1 stopped at the wound; this one leaps past everything to Kahlo. The author is not *analysing* Kahlo's paintings — he mentions her work in general terms and uses her as an example. And more importantly, the frame of the passage is not Kahlo and her suffering. The frame is kenotic theology applied to colonisation. Kahlo is brought in to illustrate a point that was already being made. An option that makes her the subject has mistaken the example for the argument. The author himself warns you against this — *"The work of Frida Kahlo is an example of..."*

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by Gejo Sreenivasan

OVERALL LEARNING

Step back from the four questions and you will see the same skill being tested each time. Every one of these Global questions is, at its core, a question about your *reading*. If the doodles are clean, if the arc is held, if Kahlo has been correctly placed as an example and kenosis has been correctly placed as a lens, then each question answers itself. The option-work at the end becomes a matter of elimination, not evaluation.

That is the real takeaway. Global questions are the type your doodles were built for. When you see one, the instinct is right — it should feel like the passage is telling you *"pick me, pick me."* But the instinct also has a failure mode, which is

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That is the real takeaway. Global questions are the type your doodles were built for. When you see one, the instinct is right — it should feel like the passage is telling you *"pick me, pick me."* But the instinct also has a failure mode, which is to relax. Do not. The setter is counting on that relaxation. The familiarity trap — the Sidetrack-truth that describes one real paragraph beautifully — is engineered for exactly this moment.

Three disciplines to carry into every Global question from here on.

One. Anticipate before you read the options. On a Main Idea question, hold the key ideas. On an Attitude question, hold the author's verbs — the things he is doing with the concept. On a Keyword question, hold the big ideas. On a Purpose question, hold the author's act. Walk into the options knowing what you are looking for.

Two. Respect the Sidetrack. More than four in ten wrong options in Global questions are true statements that answer a different question. If your reason for marking an option is "this is what the passage said," you have not yet tested it against the question being asked. Do that test before you commit.

Three. Watch the verb. Especially in Purpose and Attitude questions, the trap lives inside a single word. *Documents. Critiques. Analyses. Embraces. Detached.* These verbs look like decoration, but they are the whole option. A right verb with wrong content is still wrong. A wrong verb with right content is still wrong. Check the verb first.

Do that, and this 11.4% of the paper becomes one of the highest-accuracy segments you own.

Lesson 2.2: Global Questions – Part 2

Module: Know the Question Stems – RC

SETTING UP THIS LESSON

In the previous lesson, we broke open the four classical global question types — **Main Idea**, **Purpose / Function**, **Author's Attitude**, and **Keyword Mapping**. The framing varied slightly in each, but the spine was the same. Each one asked: have you understood the big picture?

This lesson picks up exactly where that one left off. Four more global subtypes. Same family, different faces. The Question Setter has simply learned to dress the same demand in new clothes.

- Main Idea becomes *"which sentence from the passage carries the main argument."*
- Purpose becomes *"what paragraph would logically come next."*
- Author's Attitude becomes *"where would this passage appear."*
- Keyword Mapping becomes *"sum up the transformation described in the passage."*

What you should walk out of this lesson with:

- **Quote-Based Main Idea** — the sentence that argues the issue, not the one that feels profound.
- **Continuation** — extend the argument. Don't repeat, don't escalate, don't drift.
- **Likely Source** — match the voice, not the topic.
- **Arc Summary** — before, after, driver. Miss one and the option is wrong.

One thing to hold on to before we begin: whatever shape the question takes, the answer still comes from the passage. If you have understood the passage, you can answer a Quote question, a Continuation question, a Source question, and an Arc Summary question — without learning four fresh "methods."

The **doodle** never stops doing work. It just keeps earning, question after question.

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by Gejo Sreenivasan

THE PASSAGE

- ***Source:*** *Serena Jampel, Earth's Smells Are Disappearing Because of Climate Change, and It's a Vast Cultural Loss. Smithsonian Magazine.*
- ***Stats:*** *512 words · 31 sentences · 16.5 average words per sentence · Flesch–Kincaid grade 10.9.*

*Grade 10.9 is breezy, magazine-feature prose. Don't let the ease fool you — this passage has been chosen precisely because the **reading is easy and the options are a bit challenging**. That is by design. If you are making mistakes on options like these in practice, it is fine. The confusion is the lesson.*

Smells are all around us, inseparable from the air we breathe and the spaces we inhabit. What we know as a scent is a collection of natural or artificial airborne chemicals released from objects as they vaporize in heat or slowly decay. Humans smell by inhaling these chemical components through our noses. Mucus dissolves the molecules and binds them to olfactory receptors on hair-like strands inside the nasal cavity. The receptors send neurological signals that our brain interprets as smell. . . .

Smell is deeply connected to memory because of how closely situated odor signals are to the amygdala, which processes emotion, and the hippocampus, linked to memory. Odor-based memories can be nearly instantaneous, conjuring past experiences before the conscious mind registers the scent. Familiar smells can evoke a powerful nostalgia that enhances self-esteem, social connectedness and the feeling that one's life has deeper meaning. Research has shown that exposure to evocative scents even has beneficial physiological effects. . . .

But despite its prevalence in our lives, smell is often overlooked and undervalued. . . . In an increasingly

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Grade 10.9 is breezy, magazine-feature prose. Don't let the ease fool you — this passage has been chosen precisely because the ***reading is easy and the options are a bit challenging****. That is by design. If you are making mistakes on options like these in practice, it is fine. The confusion is the lesson.*

Smells are all around us, inseparable from the air we breathe and the spaces we inhabit. What we know as a scent is a collection of natural or artificial airborne chemicals released from objects as they vaporize in heat or slowly decay. Humans smell by inhaling these chemical components through our noses. Mucus dissolves the molecules and binds them to olfactory receptors on hair-like strands inside the nasal cavity. The receptors send neurological signals that our brain interprets as smell. . . .

Smell is deeply connected to memory because of how closely situated odor signals are to the amygdala, which processes emotion, and the hippocampus, linked to memory. Odor-based memories can be nearly instantaneous, conjuring past experiences before the conscious mind registers the scent. Familiar smells can evoke a powerful nostalgia that enhances self-esteem, social connectedness and the feeling that one's life has deeper meaning. Research has shown that exposure to evocative scents even has beneficial physiological effects. . . .

But despite its prevalence in our lives, smell is often overlooked and undervalued. . . . In an increasingly audio/visual world — made even more so by our reliance on screens and disconnection from the outdoors — smell may not often be top of mind. A 2022 study found that over a quarter of college students surveyed would rather give up their sense of smell than their phone. So, as climate change and biodiversity loss threaten natural scents, thereby threatening both health and heritage, many people may not even notice. . . .

Whether or not we pay attention to the world's "scentscape," heat and pollution are causing it to shift. As temperatures rise, man-made substances release more scent molecules, and biodiversity loss due to climate change threatens the plants that scent the environment. . . . If you go to a forest, you have a given environment and temperature. If that temperature goes a little bit high, you change the profile of the chemical components in the air, since temperature can affect the amount of smell-carrying gas particles released from substances. . . . That effect extends beyond forests. Snow — already threatened by a warming climate — absorbs different chemicals from the atmosphere as temperatures rise, which alters its cold-clean scent. Warmer conditions can intensify odors, leading the snow to grow more pungent and potentially accumulate more pollutants. . . .

Scientists are only beginning to understand how the loss of smell affects human well-being. Research suggests that anthropogenic activity that damages or destroys natural scent environments is a detriment to human health and happiness. On top of that, it could reduce a person's capacity to smell at all. . . . A world without smells would be a more depressing place — literally. Since the Covid-19 pandemic, loss of smell — also known as anosmia — has been growing in prominence. In a survey of 322 people who lost their sense of smell and/or taste from COVID, 56 per cent reported a decline in overall quality of life, and 43 per cent reported depression linked to that sensory loss. . . .

Some of climate change's effects on smells are likely irrevocable. And because scientific research is trailing behind the rate of change, we don't know what we're losing. . . .

PARAGRAPH-WISE UNDERSTANDING (THE DOODLES)

Paragraph 1 opens with a fair amount of science. Chemicals released from objects, mucus dissolving molecules, olfactory receptors sending signals to the brain. If you are the type to panic when a passage gets "sciency," this is where the panic would start. Don't. The author is only laying the groundwork — smell is a chemical process that the brain interprets. That is the doodle. Nothing more is needed here.
Doodle: Smell is a chemical process interpreted by the brain.

Paragraph 2 shifts gears completely. The how-it-works is done. Now the author is telling you **why smell matters** — memory, emotion, self-esteem, social connectedness, a deeper sense of meaning. Look at the vocabulary: *self-esteem*, *deeper meaning*, *beneficial physiological effects*. These are not small words. The author is quietly building a case that smell is essential to our existence.
Doodle: Smell is deeply tied to memory, emotion, and well-being.

Paragraph 3 begins with a **But**. This is where the argument breaks open. Despite how important smell is, we overlook and undervalue it. A 2022 study is offered to show just how casually we dismiss it — a quarter of college students would rather lose their sense of smell than their phone. And the payoff sentence is at the end: because we don't care about smell, when climate change and biodiversity loss threaten it, we don't even notice. Notice how cleanly this paragraph sets up the rest of the piece. Until now, everything has been background. Here, the real argument lands.

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Doodle: Smell is undervalued despite its deep importance.

Paragraph 4 is the **mechanism paragraph**. The author introduces the word *scentscape* — the natural scent profile of the world — and explains how heat and pollution are reshaping it. Temperature rises, chemical profiles shift, biodiversity loss removes the plants that scent the environment, even snow starts smelling different. This paragraph is dense with detail, but the job of the paragraph is simple. Climate change is reshaping the scentscape. Don't get lost in the forests and the snow.
Doodle: Climate change is reshaping the world's scentscape.

Paragraph 5 drives home the consequence. If smell goes, human well-being goes with it. Anosmia post-COVID is offered as evidence — more than half of those who lost smell reported a decline in quality of life, and nearly half reported depression. The author is building the case that this is not a decorative loss. It is a real health and happiness loss.
Doodle: Losing smell damages human health and happiness.

Paragraph 6 closes with two sharp sentences. Some of these effects are irrevocable. And because science is trailing the rate of change, **we don't know what we're losing**. It is a striking line. Be careful — it feels like the thesis. It is not. It is a closing note. The real argument of the passage has already been made.
Doodle: We are losing scents before we can study them.

What the passage is really saying

Put the doodles together and the passage arc lands cleanly. Smell is a chemical process. Smell is deeply important. We undervalue it anyway. Climate change is reshaping it. Losing it damages us. And we are losing it faster than we are studying it. The author is telling us there is a problem — a problem we are barely paying attention to. That is the idea. That is the purpose. The attitude is not alarmist, not polemical — the author is **systematically laying out a case for why we should care** about the loss of smell.

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by Gejo Sreenivasan

The four new global subtypes

Before we attempt the questions, here is the cheat sheet. Keep this in mind as you read each question stem.

01 · Main Idea (Quote-Based)

- **The Demand:** Which sentence from the passage carries the main argument — in full?
- **Anticipate:** The right quote names the cause, the stakes, and the twist. Closing lines are beautiful. They are rarely the argument.
- **Typical Distortion:** Sidetrack.

02 · Continuation

- **The Demand:** What paragraph would most logically come next?

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02 · Continuation

- **The Demand:** What paragraph would most logically come next?
- **Anticipate:** A continuation extends. It does not repeat, it does not escalate, it does not change the subject. Match direction, tone, and scope.
- **Typical Distortion:** Scope Error.

03 · Likely Source

- **The Demand:** Which publication's voice, register, and purpose match the passage?
- **Anticipate:** This is a tone question wearing a source question's clothes. Read the writing, not the topic. Who would sound like this?
- **Typical Distortion:** Tone Mismatch.

04 · Arc Summary

- **The Demand:** Name the transformation — before-state, driver, after-state, and any twist.
- **Anticipate:** A correct arc carries all the load-bearing parts. Miss one, the option is wrong.
- **Typical Distortion:** Sidetrack.

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QUESTION 1 · MAIN IDEA (QUOTE-BASED)

Which of the following quotes best captures the main issue that the author is addressing?

(1) "Smell is deeply connected to memory because of how closely situated odor signals are to the amygdala, which processes emotion, and the hippocampus, linked to memory."
(2) "And because scientific research is trailing behind the rate of change, we don't know what we're losing."
(3) "Warmer conditions can intensify odors, leading the snow to grow more pungent and potentially accumulate

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(1) "Smell is deeply connected to memory because of how closely situated odor signals are to the amygdala, which processes emotion, and the hippocampus, linked to memory."
(2) "And because scientific research is trailing behind the rate of change, we don't know what we're losing."
(3) "Warmer conditions can intensify odors, leading the snow to grow more pungent and potentially accumulate more pollutants."
(4) "So, as climate change and biodiversity loss threaten natural scents, thereby threatening both health and heritage, many people may not even notice."

Correct Answer: (4)

The Logic: This is a quote-based main idea question. The trap that walks in first with these questions is the pretty sentence — the one that sounds profound, usually the closing line. Long-form magazine writing almost always ends on a line designed to linger. It is sentimental by design. That is why you must resist the pull of beauty and hunt for the sentence that does actual argumentative work.

The Passage Evidence: The passage moves from how smell works, to why it matters, to the fact that we ignore it, to climate change threatening it, to the human cost, to the urgency of the loss. The main issue binds **smell**, **climate change / biodiversity loss**, **consequence for humans**, and **our failure to notice** — all in one breath.

The Anticipated Answer: A sentence that names the cause (climate change and biodiversity loss), the stakes (health and heritage), and the twist (many people may not even notice). All three, in one line.

Option 1: Logic (Sidetrack – Setup Truth): This is one piece of the importance-of-smell argument from Paragraph 2. It is true. But it describes **why smell matters mechanistically**, not the issue the author is addressing. The main argument happens *after* the "but" in Paragraph 3 — everything before that is setup. This option gives you the setup and pretends it is the argument. Classic sidetrack.

Option 2: Logic (Sidetrack – Closing Line): This is the dangerous one. It is the final sentence of the passage, and final sentences in magazine writing sound thesis-like. It will feel right for that reason alone. Look at what it actually says though: scientific research is trailing behind the rate of change. Is the passage blaming scientific research? No. The passage is not a complaint against researchers — the author even notes in Paragraph 5 that "scientists are only beginning to understand" the problem, which is simply an observation, not a critique. The main issue is the **loss of smell and our inattention to it**, not the pace of science. This is a closing line masquerading as the argument.

Option 3: Logic (Sidetrack – Narrow Mechanism): This is an absolute sidetrack. It picks up a single detail from Paragraph 4 — snow becoming more pungent — and pretends it is the main point. The snow line is one instance of the scentscape shifting. It is a mechanism detail, not an argument. Pungent snow is not the issue the author is addressing.

Option 4: Correct Answer: This is the sentence that holds everything. *"climate change and biodiversity loss"* names the driver. *"threaten natural scents"* names the event. *"thereby threatening both health and heritage"* names the stakes. *"many people may not even notice"* names the twist — which is the entire emotional engine of the piece. Every load-bearing part of the passage is in this one sentence. By the time you reached this option, having doodled cleanly through all six paragraphs, it should have felt almost inevitable.

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QUESTION 2 · CONTINUATION

Which of the following is the most logical continuation of the passage?

(1) A discussion of what researchers, policymakers, and individuals can do to begin documenting and protecting the world's vanishing scent environments.

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QUESTION 2 · CONTINUATION

Which of the following is the most logical continuation of the passage?

(1) A discussion of what researchers, policymakers, and individuals can do to begin documenting and protecting the world's vanishing scent environments.
(2) A detailed account of the biochemistry of olfactory receptors and the neurological pathways through which the human brain processes different categories of smell.
(3) A call for immediate global action against climate change, warning that without drastic intervention, humanity will face catastrophic sensory and ecological collapse.
(4) An exploration of how other senses, especially hearing and taste, are similarly being affected by climate change and are equally deserving of scientific attention.

Correct Answer: (1)

The Logic: Continuation questions ask you to imagine what the next paragraph would be. The discipline here is elimination. You cannot predict the exact topic of the next paragraph, but you can cleanly identify what a good continuation **does not do**:

- It does not **repeat** what has already been said. The author has moved past the process of smell, past the importance of smell, past the climate mechanism. There is no going back to those stations.
- It does not **escalate the tone** without warrant. If the author has been measured throughout, a sudden alarmist paragraph does not belong. Voice must carry.
- It does not **change the subject**. The piece has been about smell. A continuation stays about smell.

The Anticipated Answer: The author has established the problem — smell is important, we are losing it, we don't even notice, and the loss is irrevocable. A natural next movement is the **solution / response / what-can-be-done** arc.

Option 1: Correct Answer: A discussion of what researchers, policymakers, and individuals can do to begin documenting and protecting the world's vanishing scent environments. Problem established → response proposed. Same subject (smell, scent environments). Same tone (measured, constructive). Same scope (connects to the author's concerns about research lagging and public inattention). This extends the argument cleanly. It is the natural next station on the train line the author has been riding.

Option 2: Logic (Scope Eror – Going Backwards): A detailed account of the biochemistry of olfactory receptors and neurological pathways. Look at where this sits — it is the content of Paragraph 1. The author has already laid out the mechanics of smell. Dragging the reader back to olfactory biochemistry six paragraphs later is not extension; it is **repetition with more detail**. A good author does not rewind. This breaks the continuation principle outright.

Option 3: Logic (Tone Mismatch – Alarmist Creep): A call for immediate global action, warning of catastrophic sensory and ecological collapse. Read the intensity of that sentence. *Immediate. Drastic intervention. Catastrophic collapse*. Now read the passage. Nowhere does the author speak in this register. The tone throughout is observational, factual, gently urgent at best. To slide into catastrophic-collapse language in the next paragraph would be the author abandoning their own voice. Continuation must match tone. This option fails that test loudly.

Option 4: Logic (Scope Error – Subject Drift): An exploration of how other senses — hearing and taste — are similarly affected. This commits two errors. First, the whole passage has been about smell; broadening into the other senses changes the subject entirely. Second, the author's specific argument in Paragraph 3 is that smell is **undervalued in an audio/visual world** — that hearing and sight already dominate our attention. For the author to then pivot and say "by the way, let's talk about hearing and taste" contradicts the very claim they just built. It would also dilute their core point that smell needs special attention. Wrong subject, wrong logic.

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QUESTION 3 · LIKELY SOURCE

This passage is most likely to have appeared in:

(1) A peer-reviewed scientific journal article presenting original research on the neurological pathways involved in human olfaction and memory.
(2) A long-form magazine feature exploring the cultural and environmental dimensions of a scientific subject for a general reading audience.
(3) An advocacy newsletter from an environmental organisation urging urgent policy action against the effects of climate change on the natural world.

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(3) An advocacy newsletter from an environmental organisation urging urgent policy action against the effects of climate change on the natural world.
(4) A policy briefing prepared for government regulators on the conservation priorities needed to protect biodiversity from climate-related loss.

Correct Answer: (2)

The Logic: Likely Source is a tone question in disguise. Don't try to guess whether it's the Guardian or the BBC or the New Yorker. That is not what is being asked. You are being asked **who would sound like this** — journal, magazine, briefing, newsletter, textbook, campaign. Each of those has a voice, a register, and a purpose. The best approach is to read the passage's voice and then eliminate the options that don't match.

The Voice of This Passage: Written for a general audience, not specialists. The tone is exploratory and observational — the author is genuinely engaged with the topic but is not issuing a call to arms. Technical terms appear (amygdala, hippocampus, olfactory receptors, anosmia), but they are explained conversationally. The piece mixes science, culture, and a light personal concern. This is the signature of magazine-feature writing.

The Anticipated Answer: A long-form piece in a general-interest magazine, aimed at a non-specialist reader.

Option 1: Logic (Tone Mismatch – Wrong Register): A peer-reviewed scientific journal presenting original research on olfactory neurology. Two problems here. First, peer-reviewed journals are written **by scientists for scientists**, in a dense technical register — not the breezy voice you have just read. Second, original research on neurological pathways would be a pure-science paper, which is the content of Paragraph 1 only. The rest of the passage is cultural and environmental commentary — entirely outside what a neurology paper would cover.

Option 2: Correct Answer: A long-form magazine feature exploring the cultural and environmental dimensions of a scientific subject for a general reading audience. This nails every element. **Long-form** — matches the multi-paragraph sprawl that moves across science, culture, and consequence. **Magazine feature** — matches the conversational register. **Cultural and environmental dimensions of a scientific subject** — matches exactly what the passage is doing: treating smell not just as biology but as heritage, memory, and environmental loss. **General reading audience** — matches the fact that technical terms are always unpacked rather than assumed.

Option 3: Logic (Tone Mismatch – Activist Register): An advocacy newsletter from an environmental organisation urging urgent policy action. Advocacy writing has a specific signature — a **call to action**, a clear ask, language that mobilises readers to do something. The passage has none of this. The author never demands policy, never asks you to sign anything, never names the enemy. The author is simply observing and reporting. An advocacy newsletter would read very differently.

Option 4: Logic (Tone Mismatch – Institutional Register): A policy briefing for government regulators on conservation priorities. Policy briefings are written for **decision-makers** — they are structured, bureaucratic, heavy on priorities and recommendations, light on cultural reflection. The piece you just read spends considerable time on self-esteem, nostalgia, deeper meaning, and cold-clean snow scents. None of that would appear in a regulator's briefing. Wrong register, wrong audience.

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QUESTION 4 · ARC SUMMARY

Which one of the following best sums up the transformation of the world's scentscape described in the passage?

(1) Once rich and stable, the world's scentscape is being altered by climate change and biodiversity loss into something degraded and diminished, with humans largely unaware of what is being lost.
(2) Once shaped by diverse natural environments, the world's scentscape has shifted toward a narrower range of urban and industrial odors as modern ways of life have distanced people from the outdoors.
(3) Once characterised by subtle and balanced natural fragrances, the world's scentscape is becoming more